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## PRELIMS 2025



# ANCIENT & MEDIEVAL INDIAN HISTORY

## REVISION SHORT NOTES



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## **Prehistoric & Harappan Period**

### **Prehistoric period**

- No written records are available
- Development of archaeology and archaeological remains helps much to understand the life and culture of the people who lived in this period
- Archaeological remains- stone tools, pottery, artifacts, and metal implements used by prehistoric people

### **Dating technique of prehistoric age**

- Radio-carbon dating- It is based on measuring the loss of carbon in organic materials over a period of time

- Dendro-Chronology- refers to the number of tree rings in wood. By counting, the number of tree rings in the wood, the date of the wood is arrived at

Famous sites of Old Stone Age (2 mn BCE to 10000 BCE) in India:

- Soan valley and Potwar plateau
- Siwalik hills on the north India
- Bhimbetka in Madhya Pradesh
- Adamgarh Hills in Narmada Valley
- Kurnool in Andhra Pradesh
- Attirampakkam near Chennai

**Characteristic features:**

- Hunter gatherers- food was obtained by hunting animals and gathering edible plants and tubers
- They used stone tools, hand-sized and flaked-off large pebbles for hunting animals
- Stone implements are made of a hard rock called quartzite
- Language and communication were not well known
- Their way of life became modified with the passage of time since they made attempts to domesticate animals, make crude pots and grow some plants
- A few Old Stone Age paintings have also been found on rocks at Bhimbetka and other places

**Mesolithic or Middle Stone Age (10000 BCE- 6000 BCE)**

This is the transitional phase between the paleolithic and neolithic ages.

Famous sites:

- Langhnaj in Gujarat
- Adamgarh in Madhya Pradesh
- Some places of Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh and Bihar

**Characteristic features:**

- Paintings and engravings found at the rock shelters give an idea about the social life and economic activities of Mesolithic people
- The hunting gathering pattern of life continued
- Seems to have been a shift from big animal hunting to small ones, and fishing
- Different types of stone tools are found. These are tiny stone artifacts, often more than five centimetres in size, and therefore called microliths
- The use of bow and arrow began in this period
- Tend to settle for longer periods in an area. Therefore, domestication of animals, horticulture and primitive cultivation started
- Animal bones are found in these sites and these include dog, deer, boar and ostrich

- Occasionally, burials of the dead along with some microliths and shells seem to have been practised

### **Neolithic age (6000 BCE- 4000 BCE)**

Important sites :

- Kashmir valley
- Chirand in Bihar
- Belan valley, UP
- Several places in the Deccan
- South India- Maski, Brahmagiri, Hallur and Kodekal in Karnataka, Paiyampalli in TN and Utnur in Andhra Pradesh

### **Characteristic features:**

- Practice of agriculture, domestication of animals, polishing of stone tools and manufacture of pottery
- Cultivation of plants and domestication of animals led to emergence of village communities based on sedentary life
- Mud brick houses were built instead of grass huts
- Wheels were used to make pottery. Pottery was used for cooking as well as storage of food grains
- There was also improvement in agriculture. Wheat, barley, rice, millet were cultivated. Rice cultivation was extensive in eastern India
- Domestication of sheep, goats and cattle was widely prevalent. Cattle were used for cultivation and for transport
- The people of Neolithic age used clothes made of cotton and wool
- Improvement in technology of making tools and other equipment. Stone tools were now polished for hunting and cutting trees

### **Metal Age or Chalcolithic (copper-stone) period**

- When copper and bronze came to be used. The new technology developed of smelting metal ore and crafting metal artifacts
- But the use of stone tools was not given up. Some of the microlithic tools continued to be essential items
- People began to travel for a long distance to obtain metal ores, that's why Chalcolithic cultures were found in many parts of India
- Chalcolithic cultures had grown in river valleys, Harappan culture is considered part of Chalcolithic culture
- Several bronze and copper objects, terracotta figurines and pottery were found at Paiyampalli in TN

## **Iron Age (1200 BCE- 600 BCE)**

- The Chalcolithic age is followed by Iron Age
- Iron is frequently referred to in the Vedas
- The Iron Age of the southern peninsula is often related to megalithic burials. Megalith means large stone
- The burial pits were covered with these stones are extensively found in South India

Important megalithic sites :

- Hallur and Maski in Karnataka, Nagarjunakonda in Andhra Pradesh and Adichchanallur in Tamil Nadu
- Black and red pottery, iron artifacts such as hoes and sickles and small weapons were found in the burial pits

## **The Harappan Civilization**

It was first called the Indus Valley Civilization. But later it was named as the Indus Civilization. The earliest excavations in the Indus Valley were done at Harappa in the West Punjab and Mohenjodaro in Sindh (both now in Pakistan)

### **Origin and Evolution**

Gradual development with four important stages or phases of evolution- pre, early, mature and late Harappan phases.

#### **Pre-Harappan stage :**

- Located in eastern Balochistan. The excavations at Mehrgarh 150 miles to the northwest of Mohenjodaro reveal the existence of pre Harappan culture
- The nomadic people began to lead a settled agricultural life

#### **Early Harappan stage :**

- People lived in large villages in the plains
- There was a gradual growth of towns in the Indus Valley
- Also, the transition from rural to urban life took place during this period
- The sites of Amri and Kot Diji remain the evidence for early Harappan stage

#### **Mature Harappan stage :**

- Great cities emerged. The excavations at Kalibangan with its elaborate town planning and urban features prove this phase of evolution

### **Late Harappan stage:**

- Decline of the Indus culture started
- The excavations at Lothal reveal this stage of evolution
- Lothal remained an emporium of trade between the Harappan civilization and the remaining part of India as well as Mesopotamia

### **Date of Harappan culture:**

- The advent of the radiocarbon method paves way for fixing almost accurate dates
- D.P. Agarwal concluded the total span of this culture should be between 2300 and 1750 BCE

### **Important sites**

- Kot Diji in Sindh
- Kalibangan in Rajasthan
- Rupar in Punjab
- Banawali in Haryana
- Lothal, Surkotada, Dholavira in Gujarat

### **Salient features of the Harappan Culture**

#### **Town planning:**

- On the lines of the grid system, that is streets and lanes cutting across one another almost at right angles thus dividing the city into several rectangular blocks
- Harappa, Mohenjodaro and Kalibangan each had its own citadel built on a high podium of mud brick
- Below the citadel in each city lay a lower town containing brick houses, which were inhabited by the common people
- Citadel of Harappa had as many as six granaries

#### **Important characteristics:**

- The large scale use of burnt bricks in constructions and the absence of stone buildings
- Another remarkable feature was the underground drainage system connecting all houses to the street drains which were covered by stone slabs or bricks

**The Great Bath at Mohenjodaro-** the most important public place measuring 39 feet length, 23 feet breadth and 8 feet depth. It must have served as a ritual bathing site. The floor of the bath was made of burnt bricks.

#### **Economic life:**

- Progress in all spheres of economic activity such as agriculture, industry and crafts and trade
- Wheat and barley were the main crops grown beside sesame, mustard and cotton
- Granaries for storage
- Animals like sheep, goats and buffalo were domesticated
- The use of horse is not yet firmly established
- A number of other animals were hunted for food including deer

**Trade:**

- Foreign trade was mainly conducted with Mesopotamia, Afghanistan and Iran
- Imported products- gold, copper, tin and several semi-precious stones
- Main exports were several agricultural products such as wheat, barley, peas, oilseeds and a variety of finished products including cotton goods, pottery, beads, terracotta figures and ivory products
- There is much evidence to prove the trade links between the Indus and Sumerian people. Many seals of Indus Valley have been found in Mesopotamia
- Trade was of the barter type
- The seals and the terracotta models of the Indus Valley reveal the use of bullock carts and oxen for land transport and boats and ships for river and sea transport.

**Social life:**

- The dress of both men and women consisted of two pieces of cloth, one upper garment and other lower garment
- Beads were worn by men and women. Jewelleries such as bangles, bracelets, fillets, girdles, anklets, earrings and finger rings were worn by women
- These ornaments were made of gold, silver, bronze, copper and semi precious stones
- Use of cosmetics was common
- Various household articles made of pottery, stone, shells, ivory and metal have been found at Mohenjodaro
- Spindles, needles, combs, fish hooks, knives are made of copper
- Children's toys include little clay carts. Marbles, balls and dice were used for games
- Fishing was a regular occupation while hunting and bull fighting were other pastimes

**Script:**

- The Harappan script is yet to be fully deciphered
- The script was mostly written from right to left
- In a few long seals, the boustrophedon method of writing in the reverse direction in alternate lines was adopted

**Religion:**



- Pasupati (proto-Siva)- the chief male deity represented in seals as sitting in a yogic position with three faces and two horns. He is surrounded by four animals (elephant, tiger, rhino and buffalo each facing a different direction)

#### **Burial methods:**

- Complete burial and post cremation were popular at Mohenjodaro
- At Lothal, the burial pit was lined with burnt bricks indicating the use of coffins
- Wooden coffins were also found at Harappa
- However, there is no clear evidence for the practice of sati

#### **Decline of the Harappan Culture:**

- There is no clear evidence regarding the cause for the decline of the Harappan culture. Various theories have been postulated
- By natural calamities like recurring floods, drying up of rivers, decreasing fertility of the soil due to excessive exploitation and occasional earthquakes might have caused the decline of the Harappan cities
- Invasion- according to some scholars, the final blow was delivered by the invasion of the Aryans
- The destruction of forts is mentioned in the Rig veda
- The discovery of human skeletons huddled together at Mohenjodaro indicates that the city was invaded by foreigners
- The Aryans had superior weapons as well as swift horses which might have enabled them to become masters of the region

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## **Vedic Period**

- The cities of Harappan culture had declined by 1500 BCE
- Consequently, around this period, Indo-Aryans who spoke Sanskrit, entered the north west India from the Indo-Iranian region
- Initial settlements in the valleys of northwest and the plains of Punjab
- Later, they moved to the Gangetic plains

#### **Original home of the Aryans:**

- A debatable question and there are several views. Different scholars have identified different regions as the original home of the Aryans
- They include the Arctic region, Germany, Central Asia and southern Russia

- However, the theory of southern Russia appears to be more probable and widely accepted by historians. From there, the Aryans moved to different parts of Asia and Europe. They entered India around 1500 BCE.

### **Vedic literature:**

The word 'Veda' is derived from the root 'vid', which means to know. In other words, the term 'Veda' signifies 'superior knowledge'.

- Rig veda- earliest of the four vedas and it consists of 1028 hymns. They were sung in praise of various gods.
- Yajur veda- consists of various details of rules to be observed at the time of sacrifice.
- Sama veda- is set to tune for the purpose of chanting during sacrifice. It is called the book of chants and the origins of Indian music are traced in it.
- Atharva veda contains details of rituals.

Other sacred words:

- Brahmanas- the treatises relating to prayer and sacrificial ceremony
- Upanishads- philosophical texts dealing with topics like the soul, the absolute and the mysteries of nature
- Aranyakas- are called forest books and they deal with mysticism, rites, rituals and sacrifices
- Epics ramayana and mahabharata- the author of Ramayana was Valmiki and that of Mahabharata was Vedvyasa

### **Rig Vedic Age or Early Vedic Period (1500-1000 BCE)**

- During this period, the Aryans were mostly confined to the Indus region
- The Rig Veda refers to Sapta Sindhu or the land of seven rivers. This includes the five rivers of Punjab- Jhelum, Chenab, Ravi, Beas and Sutlej, alongwith Indus and Saraswati.

### **Political organization:**

- Kula or family- basic unit
- Village or grama- several families joined together on the basis of their kinship to form a village or grama
- Gramani- leader of grama
- Visu - a larger unit
- Jana or tribe- highest political unit
- Tribal kingdoms at that time- Bharatas, Matsyas, Yedas and Purus
- Rajan or King- the head of the kingdom. The Rig Vedic Polity was normally monarchical and succession was hereditary

The King was assisted by purohita or priest and senani or commander of the army in his administration.

Two popular bodies-

- Sabha- council of elders
- Samiti- general assembly of entire people

**Social life:**

- Patriarchal society
- Family or graham- basic unit of society
- Grahapati- head of family
- Monogamy was generally practiced while polygamy was prevalent among the royal and noble families
- Women were given equal opportunities for growth and development
- Women poets- Apala, Viswara, Ghosa and Lopamudra
- Women could attend popular assemblies
- No child marriage or sati
- The eating of cow's meat was prohibited since it was a sacred animal
- Chariot racing, horse racing, music and dance were pastimes
- The social divisions were not rigid in the earlier period, as in the later one

**Economic condition:**

- Mainly pastoral people and their main occupation was cattle rearing
- Wealth was estimated in terms of cattle
- When they permanently settled in North India they began to practice agriculture

Other occupations:

- Carpentry
- Workers in metal made a variety of articles with copper, bronze and iron
- Spinning- cotton and woollen fabrics were made
- Goldsmiths made ornaments
- Potters made vessels for domestic use

**Trade:**

- Rivers served as an important means of transport. Trade was conducted on barter system
- Later times- gold coins called nishka were used as medium of exchange

**Religion:**

- They worshipped natural forces like earth, fire, wind, rain and thunder
- Important rig vedic gods- Prithvi (Earth), Agni(Fire), Vayu(Wind), Varuna(Rain) and Indra(Thunder)
- Female gods- Aditi and Usha
- No temples or idol worship
- Prayers were offered to gods in the expectations of rewards, ghee, milk and grain as offerings

### **Later Vedic Period (1000-600 BCE)**

- Aryans further moved towards the east in the Later Vedic Period. The Satapatha brahmana refers to the expansion of Aryans to the eastern Gangetic plains
- Later Vedic literature mentioned several tribal groups and kingdoms
- Growth of large kingdoms- important development, Kuru and Panchala kingdoms flourished in the beginning
- After the fall of the Kurus and Panchalas, other kingdoms like Kosala, Kasi and Videha came into prominence
- The famous ruler of Kasi was Ajatashatru. Janaka was the king of Videha with its capital at Mithila. His court was adorned by scholar Yajnavalkya
- Magadha, Anga and Vanga seem to be the easternmost tribal kingdoms
- The later Vedic texts also refer to the three divisions in India- Aryavarta, Madhyadesa, Dakshinapatha

### **Political organization:**

- Large kingdoms were formed, and so royal power increased
- Janapadas or rashtras- many jana or tribes were amalgamated to form it
- The king performed various rituals and sacrifices to strengthen his position which include
- Rajasuya (consecration ceremony), Ashwamedha (horse sacrifice), Vajpeya (chariot race)
- Other officials were involved in the administration in addition to the existing purohita, senani and gramani
- They include the treasury officer, tax collector and royal messenger
- Administration at the lower levels was carried on by the village assemblies
- The importance of the Sabha and Samiti had diminished during the later vedic period

### **Economic conditions:**

- Iron was used extensively and with the knowledge of the use of iron, they were able to clean forests and bring more lands under cultivation
- Agriculture became chief occupation
- Besides barley, rice and wheat were grown
- Knowledge of manure was an improvement

- Foreign trade also became extensive
- A class of hereditary merchants (vaniya) came into existence
- Vaishyas carried on trade and commerce in guilds known as ganas
- Besides nishka, gold and silver coins like satamana and krishnala were used as media of exchange

#### **Social life:**

- There were four divisions of the society
- The two higher classes of Brahmans and Kshatriyas enjoyed more privileges than the Vaisyas and Shudras
- Patriarchy was prevalent
- Women were considered subordinate to men
- Women lost their political rights
- Child marriages became common

#### **Religion:**

- Early Vedic nature Gods lost their importance
- Prajapati (creator), Vishnu (protector), Rudra (destroyer)
- Sacrifices became important and rituals more elaborate
- Importance of prayers declined and that of sacrifice increased
- Rise of Buddhism and Jainism
- Also, the authors of the Upanishads, which is the essence of Hindu philosophy, turned away from the useless rituals and insisted on true knowledge for peace and salvation

#### **Upavedas And Associated Vedas**

| <b>Upavedas</b>                | <b>Vedas</b> |
|--------------------------------|--------------|
| Ayurveda ( Medicine )          | Rig Veda     |
| Gandharva Veda ( Music )       | Sama Veda    |
| Dhanurveda ( Archery )         | Yajur Veda   |
| Arthveda ( Science of wealth ) | Atharva Veda |

#### **Schools Of Indian Philosophy ( Shad Darshanas )**

| <b>School</b> | <b>Founder</b> |
|---------------|----------------|
|---------------|----------------|

|                         |                   |
|-------------------------|-------------------|
| Sankhya                 | Kapila            |
| Yoga                    | Patanjali         |
| Nyaya                   | Akshapada Gautama |
| Vaishesika Darshana     | Uluka Kanada      |
| Mimansa / Purva Mimansa | Jaimini           |
| Vedant / Uttara Mimansa | Badarayana        |

### Rigvedic Names Of Indian Rivers

| River  | Rigvedic Name |
|--------|---------------|
| Indus  | Sindhu        |
| Jhelum | Vitasta       |
| Chenab | Askini        |
| Beas   | Vipasa        |
| Ravi   | Purushani     |
| Sutlej | Sutudari      |

## Jainism and Buddhism

Great thinkers like Buddha, Mahavira, Heraclitus, Zoroaster, Confucius and Lao Tse lived and preached their ideas in the 6th century BCE which enabled the rise of heterodox sects against the orthodox religion dominated by rites and rituals.

### Causes for the rise of Jainism and Buddhism

- The primary cause of the religious factor- was the religious unrest in India in the 6th century BCE
- The complex rituals and sacrifices advocated in the Later vedic period were not acceptable to the common people
- The sacrificial ceremonies were also found to be too expensive
- The superstitious beliefs and mantras confused the people

- The teachings of Upanishads, an alternative to the system of sacrifices, were highly philosophical in nature therefore not easily understood by all

What was needed in the larger interests of the people?

- A simple, short and intelligible way to salvation for all people. Such religious teachings should also be in a language known to all
- This need was fulfilled by the teachings of Buddha and Mahavira

#### **Social and economic factors:**

- The rigid caste system prevalent in India generated tensions in the society. Higher classes enjoyed certain privileges which were denied to the lower classes
- Also, the Kshatriyas had resented the domination of the priestly class
- Buddha and Mahavira belonged to Kshatriya origin
- The growth of trade led to the improvement in the economic conditions of the Vaisyas, the merchant class
- As a result, they wanted to enhance their social status but the orthodox varna system did not allow this. Therefore, they began to extend support to Buddhism and Jainism

#### **Jainism**

##### **Life of Vardhamana Mahavira (539-467 BCE):**

- Vardhamana Mahavira was the 24th tirthankara of the Jain tradition
- He was born at Kundagrama near Vaishali to Kshatriya parents Siddharta and Trisala
- He married Yasoda and gave birth to a daughter
- At the age of thirty years, he became an ascetic and wandered for twelve years
- In the 13th year of his presence, he attained the highest spiritual knowledge called Kevala Jnana. Thereafter, he was called Mahavira and Jina
- His followers were called Jains and the religion Jainism. He preached his doctrines for 30 years and died at the age of 72 at Pava near Rajgriha

##### **Teachings of Mahavira:**

The three principles of Jainism also known as Triratnas or three gems are:

- Right faith- belief in the teachings and wisdom of Mahavira
- Right knowledge- acceptance of the theory that there is no God and that the world has been existing without a creator and that all objects possess a soul
- Right conduct- observance of the 5 doctrines--
  - Not to injure life
  - Not to lie
  - Not to steal
  - Not to acquire property

- Not to lead an immoral life

### **Other teachings:**

- Strictly follow the doctrine of ahimsa. It regarded that all objects, both animate and inanimate, have souls and possess life and feel pain when they are injured
- Mahavira rejected the authority of the Vedas and objected to the Vedic rituals. He advocated a very holy and ethical code of life
- Even the practice of agriculture was considered sinful as it causes injury to the earth, worms and animals
- To carry out the doctrine of asceticism and renunciation to extreme lengths by the practice of starvation, nudity and other forms of self-torture

### **Spread of Jainism:**

- Mahavira organized the Sangha to spread his teachings
- He admitted both men and women in the Sangha, and it spread rapidly and widely in Western India and Karnataka
- Rulers and dynasties who patronized Jainism- Chandragupta Maurya, Kharvela of Kalinga and royal dynasties of south India such as the Ganges, the Kadambas, the Chalukyas and the Rashtrakutas

### **Division:**

- By the end of the 4th century BCE, there was a serious famine in the Ganges valley. Many Jain monks led by Bhadrabahu and Chandragupta Maurya came to Shravanabelagola in Karnataka
- Those who stayed back in north India were led by a monk named Sthulabahu who changed the code of conduct for the monks
- This led to the division of Jainism into two sects Svetambaras (white clad) by Sthulabahu and Digambaras (sky-clad or naked) by Bhadrabahu

### **Jain councils**

- First Jain council
  - Held at Pataliputra in 3rd century BCE and was presided by Sthulabhadra
- Second Jain council
  - Held at Vallabhi in 512 CE and was presided by Devardhi Kshmasramana
  - Final compilations of 12 Angas and 12 Upangas

### **Buddhism**

#### **Life of Gautama Buddha (567-487 BCE):**



- Gautama or Siddharta, the founder of Buddhism, was born in 567 BCE in Lumbini Garden near Kapilavastu
- His father was Suddhodhana of the Sakya clan and mother Mayadevi
- As his mother died at childbirth, he was brought up by his aunt Parajapati Gautami
- At the age of sixteen he married Yashodhara and gave birth to a son, Rahula

What turned him into an ascetic?

- The sight of an old man, a diseased man, a corpse and an ascetic turned him away from worldly life
- He left home at the age of 29 in search of Truth

Enlightenment:

- Under a bodhi tree at Bodhgaya, he got enlightenment or nirvana, at the age of 35
- Since then he became known as the Buddha or the Enlightened One

First Sermon:

- He delivered his first sermon at Sarnath near Benares and for the next 45 years he led the life of a preacher
- He died at the age of 80 at Kushinagar

Disciples:

- Sariputta, Moggallanna, Ananda, Kassapa and Upali
- Kings like Prasenjit of Kosala and Bimbisara and Ajatasatru of Magadha accepted his doctrines and became his disciples
- He visited places like Benares, Rajgriha, Sravasti, Vaishali, Nalanda and Pataligrama

## **Teachings of Buddha**

**Four noble truths:**

- The world is full of suffering
- The cause of suffering is desire
- If desires are got rid off, suffering can be removed
- This can be done by following the Eightfold Path

**Eightfold Path:**

- Right view
- Right resolve

- Right conduct
- Right mindfulness
- Right concentration
- Right effort
- Right livelihood
- Right speech

#### **Other teachings:**

- Buddha neither accepts god nor rejects the existence of god
- He laid great emphasis on the law of karma. He argued that the condition of man in this life depends upon his own deeds
- He taught that the soul does not exist. However, he emphasized ahimsa
- He did not make a direct attack on the caste system but he was against any social distinctions and threw open his order to all
- Therefore, Buddhism was a more social than religious revolution. It taught the code of practical ethics and laid down the principle of social equality

#### **Spread of Buddhism:**

- Buddha had two kinds of disciples- monks (bhikshus) and lay worshippers (upasikas)
- Sangha- organized by the monks for the purpose of spreading his teachings
- The membership was open to all persons, male or female and without any caste restrictions
- Famous monks- Sariputta, Moggallanna, Ananda
- Progress- Magadha, Kosala, Kausambi and several Republican states of North India embraced this religion
- About 200 years after the death of Buddha, the famous Mauryan Emperor Asoka embraced Buddhism
- Transformation from a local religious sect into a world religion- Through the missionary effort of Asoka Buddhism spread into West Asia and Ceylon

#### **Buddhist Councils**

##### **First Buddhist Council**

- Was held at Rajagriha under the chairmanship of Mahakasyapa immediately after the death of Buddha
- Its purpose was to maintain the purity of the teachings of the Buddha

##### **Second Buddhist Council**

- Was convened at Vaishali around 383 BCE

##### **Third Buddhist Council**

- Held at Pataliputra under the patronage of Asoka. Moggaliputta Tissa presided over it

- The final version of Tripitakas was completed in this council

#### Fourth Buddhist Council

- Convened in Kashmir by Kanishka under the chairmanship of Vasumitra. Asvaghosha participated in this council
- The new school of Buddhism called Mahayana Buddhism came into existence during this council

The Buddhism preached by Buddha and propagated by Asoka was known as Hinayana.

Tripitakas- The compilation of Buddhist texts. These are :

- Sutta pitakas
- Vinaya pitakas
- Abhidhamma pitakas

These are written in the Pali language.

#### **Causes for the decline of Buddhism in India:**

- The revival of Brahmanism and the rise of Bhagavatism led to the fall of popularity of Buddhism
- The use of Pali, the language of the masses as the language of Buddhism was given up from the 1st century CE. The Buddhists began to adopt Sanskrit, the language of the elite
- Deterioration of moral standards- After the birth of Mahayana Buddhism, the practice of idol worship and making offerings
- Attack of the Huns in the 5th and 6th centuries and the Turkish invaders in the 12th century destroyed the monasteries
- All these factors contributed to the decline of Buddhism in India

#### **Contribution of Buddhism to Indian Culture:**

- The concept of ahimsa was its chief contribution. Later, it became one of the cherished values of our nation
- The stupas at Sanchi, Bharhut and Gaya are wonderful pieces of architecture
- Buddhism takes the credit for the chaityas and viharas in different parts of India
- It promoted education through residential universities like those at Taxila, Nalanda and Vikramshila
- The language of Pali and other local languages developed through the teachings of Buddhism
- It had also promoted the spread of Indian culture to other parts of Asia

## Buddhist Universities And Their Founders

| University  | Founder       |
|-------------|---------------|
| Nalanda     | Kumaragupta I |
| Odantpuri   | Gopala        |
| Vikramshila | Dharmapala    |
| Somapuri    | Dharmapala    |
| Vallabhi    | Bhattarika    |

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## Magadha Empire, Persian & Alexander's Invasion

In the beginning of the 6th century BCE, northern India consisted of a large number of independent kingdoms.

Monarchies- on the Gangetic plain

The Republics- on the foothills of the Himalayas and in northwestern India  
Some republics consisted of only one tribe like the Sakyas, Licchavis and Mallas.

The Buddhist literature Anguttara Nikaya gives a list of 16 great kingdoms called Sixteen Mahajanapadas.

- Anga, Magadha, Kasi, Kosala, Vajji, Malla, Chedi, Vatsa, Kuru, Panchala, Matsya, Surasena, Asmaka, Avanti, Gandhara and Kambhoja
- Finally in the mid 6th century BCE, only 4 kingdoms- Vatsa, Avanti, Kosala and Magadha survived

### Vatsa:

- Situated on the banks of the river Yamuna
- Capital was Kausambi, near modern Allahabad
- Most popular ruler- Udayana
- Strengthened his position by entering into matrimonial alliances with Avanti, Anga and Magadha
- After his death, Vatsa was annexed to the Avanti kingdom

**Avanti:**

- The capital was Ujjain
- Most important ruler- Pradyota
- He became powerful by marrying Vasavadatta, daughter of Udayana
- He patronized Buddhism. The successors of Pradyota were weak and later this kingdom was taken over by the rulers of Magadha

**Kosala:**

- Capital was Ayodhya
- Famous ruler- King Prasenjit
- His position was further strengthened by the matrimonial alliance with Magadha
- His sister was married to Bimbisara and Kasi was given to her as dowry
- After the death of this powerful king, Kosala became part of the Magadha

**Magadha:**

- Emerged as most powerful and prosperous
- Capital- Rajgriha
- It became the nerve centre of political activity in northern India
- Geographical and strategic advantages which made her to rise in imperial greatness
- Her strategic position is between the upper and lower part of the Gangetic valley. It had fertile soil
- Natural assets- the iron ores in the hills near Rajgir and copper and iron deposits near Gaya
- Wealth distribution- Her location at the centre of the highways of trade
- During the reign of Bimbisara and Ajatasatru, the prosperity of Magadha reached its zenith

**Bimbisara (546-494 BCE)**

- Belonged to the Haryanka dynasty

Matrimonial alliances- which consolidated his position

- First was with the ruling family of Kosala. He married Kosaladevi, sister of Prasenajit
- He was given the Kasi region as dowry which yielded large revenue
- Second, married Chellana, a princess of the Licchavi family of Vaishali
- This matrimonial alliance secured for him the safety of the northern frontier and facilitated the expansion of Magadha northwards to the borders of Nepal
- Third- He also married Khema of the royal house of Madras in central Punjab

Expeditions- which added more territories to the Empire.

- He defeated Brahmadatta of Anga and annexed that kingdom. He maintained friendly relations with Avanti

- He had also efficiently reorganized the administration of his kingdom
- He was a contemporary of both Vardhamana Mahavira and Gautama Buddha. However, both religions claim him as their supporter and devotee. He seems to have made numerous gifts to the Buddhist Sanghas

### **Ajatashatru (494-462 BCE)**

- Remarkable reign- for his military conquests
- Great success- He fought against Kosala and Vaisali and won a great success against a formidable confederacy led by the Licchavis of Vaishali. This had increased his power and prestige. This war lasted for about 16 years
- Ajatasatru realized the strategic importance of Pataligrama. He fortified it to serve as a convenient base of operations against Vaisali
- Buddhists and Jains both claim that Ajatasatru was a follower of their religion
- General belief says that in the beginning he was a follower of Jainism and subsequently embraced Buddhism
- He is said to have met Gautama Buddha. This scene is also depicted in the sculptures of Bharhut
- According to Mahavamsa, he constructed several chaityas and viharas
- He convened the First Buddhist Council at Rajgriha soon after the death of Buddha

### **Udayin**

- Immediate successor of Ajatasatru
- He laid the foundation of the new capital at Pataliputra situated at the confluence of two rivers- Ganges and Son
- End of the Haryanka dynasty and establishment of Sai Sunga dynasty due to weak successors of Udayin. Magadha was captured by Saisunga

### **Sai Sunga dynasty**

- Archaeology and chronology not very clear
- Saisunga defeated the king of Avanti which was made part of the Magadha empire
- After Saisunga, the mighty empire began to collapse
- His successor was Kakavarman or Kalasoka
- During his reign, second Buddhist Council was held at Vaishali
- Kalasoka was killed by the founder of the Nanda dynasty

### **Nandas**

- The fame of Magadha scaled new heights under the Nanda dynasty
- Reach- beyond the boundaries of the Gangetic basin
- Powerful ruler- Mahapadma Nanda
- He uprooted the Kshatriya dynasties in north India and assumed the title ekarat

- The Puranas speak of the extensive conquests made by him
- The Hathigumpha inscription of Kharvela of Kalinga refers to the conquest of Kalinga by the Nandas
- According to the Buddhist tradition, Mahapadma Nanda ruled for about 10 years
- He had eight sons who successively ruled, last one being Dhana Nanda. He kept the empire intact and possessed a powerful army
- They had enormous wealth, which finds mention in the Tamil Sangam work Agananuru by the poet Mamulanar
- The flourishing state of agriculture in the Nanda dominions and the general prosperity of the country must have brought to the royal treasury enormous revenue
- Dhana Nanda had an oppressive way of tax collection though
- Taking advantage of this, Chandragupta Maurya and Kautilya initiated a popular movement against the Nanda rule, during which time Alexander also invaded India

## **Persian and Greek Invasions**

### **Persian Invasions**

#### **Cyrus (558-530 BCE)**

- Cyrus the Great was the greatest conqueror of the Achaemenid Empire
- He was the first conqueror who led an expedition and entered into India
- He captured the Gandhara region. All Indian tribes to the west of the Indus river submitted to him and paid tribute

#### **Darius I (522-486 BCE)**

- Grandson of Cyrus, conquered the Indus Valley in 518 BCE and annexed the Punjab and Sindh
- This region became the 20th Satrapy of his empire. It was the most fertile and populous province of the empire
- He also sent a naval expedition under Skylas to explore the Indus

#### **Xerxes (465-456 BCE)**

- He utilised his Indian province to strengthen his position
- He deployed Indian infantry and cavalry to Greece to fight but faced a defeat in Greece
- After this failure, the Achaemenians could not follow a forward policy in India. However, the Indian province was still under their control
- Darius III enlisted Indian soldiers to fight against Alexander in 330 BCE

**Effects of the Persian Invasion-** Iranian connection with India proved more fruitful than the short-lived Macedonian contact.

- The Persian invasion provided an impetus to the growth of Indo-Iranian commerce
- Prepared the ground for Alexander's invasion
- The use of Kharosthi script, a form of Iranian writing became popular in northwestern India
- Influence of Persian art was visible on the Mauryan art, particularly the monolithic pillars of Asoka and sculptures found on them
- The very idea of issuing edicts by Asoka and the wording used in the edicts are traced to Iranian influence

### **Alexander's Invasion of India (327-325 BCE)**

#### **Political Condition on the eve of Alexander's invasion:**

- Alexander and Macedonia invaded India after 2 centuries of the Persian invasion
- Kingdoms leading Kings on the eve of his invasion- northwestern India remained disunited
- Ambhi of Taxila, the ruler of Abhisara and Porus who ruled the region between the rivers of Jhelum and Chenab
- There were many republican states like Nysa

#### **Causes of the Invasion**

- Alexander ascended the throne of Macedonia after the death of his father Philip in 334 BCE
- He conquered the whole of Persia by defeating Darius III in the battle of Arbela in 330 BCE
- He also aimed at further conquest eastwards and wanted to recover the Persian Satrapy of India
- The writings of Greek authors like Herodotus about the fabulous wealth of India attracted Alexander
- He believed that geographically there was the continuation of the sea on the eastern side of India, so he thought by conquering India, he would also conquer the eastern boundary of the world

#### **Battle of Hydaspes**

- In 327 BCE, Alexander crossed the Hindu Kush Mountains and spent nearly ten months in fighting with the tribes
- He crossed the Indus in February 326 BCE, with the help of the bridge of boats
- He was warmly received by Ambhi, the ruler of Taxila. From there, Alexander sent a message to Porus to submit
- But Porus refused and decided to fight against Alexander. He marched from Taxila to the banks of the river Hydaspes (Jhelum)



- As there were heavy floods in the river, Alexander was not able to cross it. After a few days, he crossed the river and the famous battle of Hydaspes was fought on the plains of Karri
- Alexander was impressed by the courage and heroism of this Indian prince, treated him generously and reinstated him on the throne
- Alexander continued his march as far as the river Beas encountering opposition from the local tribes
- He wanted to proceed still further eastwards towards the Gangetic valley. But his soldiers refused to fight. Hardships of prolonged warfare made them tired and they wanted to retire home
- Alexander could not persuade them and therefore decided to return. He made arrangements to look after his conquered territories in India
- He divided the whole territory from Indus to Beas into three provinces and put them under his governors
- On his return journey which began in October 326 BCE, he reached Babylon where he fell seriously ill and died in 323 BCE

### **Effects of Alexander's invasion**

- Immediate effect- it encouraged political unification of north India under the Mauryas
- The system of small independent states came to an end
- It had also paved the way for direct contact between India and Greece
- The routes opened by him and his naval expeditions increased the existing facilities for trade between India and West Asia

His authority in the Indus Valley was a short-lived one because of the expansion of the Mauryan empire under Chandragupta Maurya.

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## **The Mauryan Empire**

Significance- the political unity was achieved in India for the very first time with the foundation of the Mauryan empire

### **Kautilya's Arthashastra**

- Written by Kautilya, a contemporary of Chandragupta Maurya, most important literary source for the history of the Maurya
- Kautilya was also called Indian Machiavelli
- The manuscript of Arthashahstra was first discovered by R. Shama Sastri in 1904
- The Arthashastra is divided into three parts-
  - The first deals with the king and his council and the department and government

- The second with civil and criminal law
- The third with diplomacy and war

### **Visakadatta's Mudrarakshasa**

- Written by Visakadatta is a drama in Sanskrit which describes how Chandragupta with the assistance of Kautilya overthrew the Nandas (but written during the Gupta period)
- It also gives a picture on the socio-economic condition under the Mauryas

### **Megasthenes' Indica**

- He was the Greek ambassador in the court of Chandragupta Maurya
- His book gives details about
  - The Mauryan administration, particularly the administration of the capital city of Pataliputra and also the military organization
  - Picture on contemporary social life

### **Other literatures**

- The Puranas and the Buddhist literature such as Jatakas provide information on the Mauryas
- The Ceylonese Chronicles Dipavamsa and Mahavamsa throw light on the role Asoka in spreading Buddhism in Sri Lanka

### **Archaeological sources**

#### **Edicts of Asoka**

- The inscriptions of Asoka were first deciphered by James Prinsep in 1837
- They are written in Pali language and in some places Prakrit was used
- The Brahmi script was employed for writing
- In the northwestern India, Asokan inscriptions were found in Kharosthi Script
- Asokan inscriptions remain valuable sources for the study of Asoka and the Mauryan Empire
- There are 14 Major Rock Edicts. The major pillar edicts were erected in important cities
- There are minor Rock Edicts and minor pillar edicts
- These edicts of Asoka deal with Asoka's dhamma and also instructions given to his officials
- The XIII Rock Edicts gives details about his war with Kalinga
- The pillar edict VII gives a summary of his efforts to promote the Dhamma within his kingdom

### **Political history of the Mauryas**

### **Chandragupta Maurya (322-298 BCE)**

- Founder of the Mauryan empire
- He captured Pataliputra from the last ruler of the Nanda dynasty, Dhanananda with the help of Kautilya, also known as Chanakya or Vishnugupta
- After firmly establishing his power in the Gangetic valley, he marched to the northwest and subdued the territories up to the Indus
- Then he moved to central India and occupied the region north of Narmada river
- In 305 BCE, he marched against Alexander's General Seleucus Niketar, who was controlling northwestern India. He defeated him and a treaty was signed
- By this treaty, Seleucus Niketar ceded the trans-Indus territories- namely Aria, Arakosia and Gedrosia- to the Mauryan empire
- He also gave his daughter in marriage to the Mauryan prince
- Megasthenes was sent to the Mauryan court as Greek ambassador
- Chandragupta embraced Jainism towards the end of his life. Then he went to Shravanabelagola, near Mysore along with other Jain monks led by Bhadrabahu and starved himself to death

### **Bindusara (298-273 BCE)**

- Bindusara was called by the Greeks as "Amittagatha" meaning slayer of enemies
- He is said to have conquered the Deccan up to Mysore
- The Sangam Tamil literature confirms the Mauryan invasion of the far south
- Bindusara received Deimachus as ambassador from the Syrian king Antiochus I
- He supported the Ajivikas, a religious sect. Bindusara appointed his son Asoka as the governor of Ujjain

### **Asoka the Great (273-232 BCE)**

- There is little information regarding the early life of Asoka. He acted as Governor of Ujjain and also suppressed a revolt in Taxila during his father Bindusara's reign
- There was a struggle for the throne after Bindusara's death. The Ceylonese Chronicles, Dipavamsa and Mahavamsa state that Asoka captured power after killing his ninety nine brothers including his elder brother Susima
- But according to Taranatha of Tibet, Asoka killed only six of his brothers
- The most important event of Asoka's reign- victorious war with Kalinga in 261 BCE- effects of the war were described by Asoka himself in the Rock Edict XIII
- Effect of the Kalinga war- Asoka embraced Buddhism under the influence of Buddhist monk, Upagupta

### **Asoka and Buddhism**

- About 261 BCE, Asoka became a Sakya Upasaka (lay disciple) and two and a half years later, a Bikshu (monk)

- He visited Bodhgaya, and organized missions. He appointed special officers called Dharma Mahamatras to speed up the progress of Dhamma
- In 241 BCE, he visited the birthplace of Buddha, the Lumbini Garden, near Kapilavastu, also visited other holy places of Buddhism like Sarnath, Sravasti and Kushinagar
- He sent a mission to Sri Lanka under his son Mahendra and daughter Sanghamitra who planted there the branch of the original Bodhi tree
- Asoka convened the Third Buddhist Council at Pataliputra in 240 BCE, in order to strengthen the Sangha. It was presided over by Moggaliputta Tissa

### **Extent of Asoka's empire**

- Northwestern frontier was already demarcated by Chandragupta Maurya
- Asoka's inscriptions mention the southernmost kingdoms- Cholas, Pandyas, Satyaputras and Keralaputras as border states. Therefore these states remained outside the Mauryan empire
- According to Rajatarangini, Kashmir was a part of the Mauryan empire
- Nepal was also within the Mauryan empire

### **Asoka's Dhamma**

- His policy of dhamma was a still broad concept with elaboration of a way of life, signifies a general code of conduct and a set of principles to be adopted and practiced by the people at large
- His principles of Dhamma were clearly stated in his Edicts

Asoka's dhamma as mentioned in his various edicts may be summed up as follows:

- Service to father and mother, practice of ahimsa, love of truth, reverence to teachers and good treatment of relatives
- Prohibition of animal sacrifices and festive gatherings and avoiding expensive and meaningless ceremonies and rituals
- Efficient organization of administration in the direction of social welfare and maintenance of constant contact with people through the system of Dhamma Yatra
- Humane treatment of servants by masters and prisoners by government officials
- Consideration and non-violence to animals and courtesy to relations and liberality to Brahmins
- Tolerance among all the religious sects
- Conquest through Dhamma instead of through war

The concept of non-violence and other similar ideas of Asoka's Dhamma are identical with the teachings of Buddha. His dhamma is a general code of conduct. Asoka wished that dhamma spread through all social levels in the society.

### **Estimate of Asoka**

- Asoka was "the greatest of kings" surpassing Alexander the Great and Julius Caesar and other renowned Emperors of the world
- His dhamma is so universal that it appeals to promote the welfare of humanity and the policy of non-aggression

### **Later Mauryas**

- Asoka's death in 232 BCE was followed by the division of the Mauryan empire into two parts- eastern and western
- Due to the Bactrian invasions, the western part of the empire collapsed
- The last Mauryan king was Brihadratha, who was assassinated by Pushyamitra Sunga

### **Mauryan Administration**

#### **Central government**

- The ascendancy of the Mauryas had resulted in the triumph of monarchy in India
- Kautilya supported the monarchical form of government, he did not stand for royal absolutism
- He advocated for a council of ministers called Mantriparishad to assist the king in administrative matters
- It consisted of Purohita, Mahamantri, Senapati and Yuvaraja
- Amatyas- civil servants to look after the day-to-day administration
- Asoka appointed Dhamma Mahamatras to supervise the spread of Dhamma. Thus the Mauryan state had a well organized civil service

#### **Revenue department**

- Samharta: chief of the revenue department, was in charge of the collection of all revenues of the empire
- Sources: the revenues came from land, ferry tax, forests, mines and pastures, license fee from craftsmen and fines collected in the law courts
- The land revenue was normally fixed as one sixth of the produce

#### **Army**

- Army was well organized and it was under the control of Senapati
- The salaries were paid in cash. Kautilya refers to the salaries of different ranks of military officers
- According to Greek author Pliny, the Mauryan army consisted of six lakh infantry, thirty thousand cavalry, nine thousand elephants and eight thousand chariots
- There were the Navy and Transport and Supply wings
- Each wing was under the control of Adhyaksha or Superintendent

- Megasthenes mentions six boards of five members each to control the six wings of the military

### **Department of Commerce and Industry**

- This department had controlled the retail and wholesale prices of goods
- Adhyakshas- officers who tried to ensure their steady supply. It also controlled weights and measures, levied custom duties and regulated foreign trade

### **Judicial and Police departments**

- Kautilya mentions the existence of both civil and criminal courts
- Dharmadhikari: the chief justice of the Supreme Court at the capital
- There were also subordinate courts at the provincial capitals and districts under Amatyas
- Different kinds of punishments- imprisonment, mutilation and death
- Torture was employed to extract truth
- Both Kautilya and Asokan Edicts mention about jails and jail officials
- Remission of sentences is also mentioned in Asoka's inscriptions

### **Census**

- The taking of Census was regular during the Mauryan period
- The village officials were to number the people along with other details like their caste and occupation
- They were also to count the animals in each house
- The census in the towns was taken by municipal officials to track the movement of population both foreign and indigenous
- Spies cross checked the data collected
- The census appears to be a permanent institution in the Mauryan administration

### **Provincial and Local administration:**

- The Mauryan empire was divided into four provinces with their capitals at Taxila, Ujjain, Suvarnagiri and Kalinga
- The provincial governors were mostly appointed from the members of the royal family. They were responsible for the maintenance of law and order and collection of taxes in the empire
- The district administration was under the charge of Rajukas, whose position and functions are similar to modern collectors
- He was assisted by Yuktas or subordinate officials
- Village administration was in the hands of Gramani and his official superior called Gopa
- Gopa: in charge on ten or fifteen villages
- Both Kautilya and Megasthenes provided the system of municipal administration
- Arthashastra contains a full chapter on the role of Nagrika or city superintendent

- His chief duty was to maintain law and order
- Megasthenes refers to the six committees of five members each to look after the administration of Pataliputra
- These committees looked after- industries, foreigners, registration of birth and death certificates, trade, manufacture and sale of goods, collection of sales tax

### **Mauryan Art and Architecture**

- The monuments before the period of Asoka were mostly made of wood and therefore perished
- The use of stone started from the time of Asoka
- His palace and monasteries and most of his stupas have disappeared
- The only remaining stupa is at Sanchi

### **Pillars**

- Asokan pillars with inscriptions were found in places like Delhi, Allahabad, Rummindei, Sanchi and Sarnath
- Their tops were crowned with figures of animals like lion, elephant and bull
- The Sarnath pillar with four lions standing back to back is the most significant
- The Indian government adopted this capital with some modifications as its state emblem

### **Stupas**

- Majority of them were destroyed during foreign invasions
- Best example is the famous Sanchi stupa with massive dimensions
- Originally built by bricks but later enlarged after the time of Asoka

### **Caves**

- The caves presented to Ajivikas by Asoka and his son Dasaratha remain important heritage of the Mauryas
- Interior walls are polished like mirror
- The caves at Barabar hills near Bodhgaya are wonderful pieces of Mauryan architecture

### **Causes for the decline of the Mauryas**

- The traditional approach attributes the decline to Asoka's policies and his weak successors
- Another approach holds the inadequate political and economic institutions to sustain such a vast empire
- It was said that Asoka's pro-Buddhist policies antagonized the Brahmins who brought about a revolution led by Pusyamitra Sunga. But Asoka never acted against Brahmins

- Another charge against him was his policy of non-violence reduced the fighting spirit of his army
  - Blaming Asoka for this decline may not be correct because he was more a pragmatist than an idealist
  - Multiple causes- weak successors, partition of empire, administrative abuses after Asoka's reign
- 

## Post- Mauryan Period

### Sungas

- Mauryan rule was replaced by the Sunga dynasty
- Founder- Pushyamitra Sunga, who was the commander-in-chief under the Mauryas
- He assassinated the last Mauryan ruler Brihadratha and usurped the throne

### Challenges to the Sunga rule

- To protect north India against the invasions of the Bactrian Greeks from the northwest
- To regain the lost territory from the Greeks already advanced up to Pataliputra
- Campaign against Kharvela of Kalinga who invaded north India

Pushyamitra followed Brahmanism. He performed two asvamedha sacrifices.

- Buddhist sources refer to him as a persecutor of Buddhism but evidences also shows that Pushyamitra patronized Buddhist art
- During his reign, the Buddhist monuments in Bharhut and Sanchi were renovated and further improved
- After the death of Pushyamitra, his son Agnimitra became the ruler
- The last Sunga ruler- Devabhuti, who was murdered by his minister Vasudeva Kanva, the founder of the Kanva dynasty
- Importance:
  - They defended the Gangetic valley from foreign invasions
  - In the cultural sphere, the Sungas revived Brahmanism and horse sacrifice
  - They also promoted the growth of Vaishnavism and the Sanskrit language

### Satavahanas

- Satavahanas also known as the Andhras established their independent rule after the decline of the Mauryas in the Deccan
- Their rule lasted for about 450 years



- The Puranas and inscriptions mention the Satavahanas. Eg- Nasik and the Nanaghad inscriptions throw much light on the reign of Gautamiputra Satkarni
- The coins issued by the Satavahanas help in knowing the economic conditions of that period
- Simuka- founder of the Satavahana dynasty, succeeded by Krishna, who extended the kingdom upto Nasik in the west
- The third king was Sri Satkarni who conquered west Malwa and Berar and also performed ashwamedha sacrifices
- The seventeenth king of the Satavahana dynasty was Hala
- He wrote the book Gathasaptasati, also known as Sattasai. It contains 700 verses in Prakrit language
- The greatest ruler of the Satavahana dynasty was Gautamiputra Satkarni (106-130 CE)
- His achievements were recorded in the Nasik inscription by his mother Gautami Balasri

### **Expansion of empire**

- Gautamiputra Satkarni captured the whole of Deccan and expanded the empire too
- He got victorious over Nagapana, the ruler of Malwa
- He patronized Brahmanism. Yet, he also gave donations to the Buddhists
- Gautamiputra Satkarni was succeeded by his son Vasista Putra Pulamayi
- He extended the Satavahana power up to the mouth of the Krishna river
- He issued coins on which the image of ships was inscribed. They reveal the naval power and maritime trade of the Satavahanas

### **Economic conditions**

- The last great ruler of the Satavahanas was Yajna Sri Satakarni
- Remarkable progress in the fields of trade and industry. Merchants organized guilds to increase their activities
- Silver coins called Karshapanas were used for trade
- Ptolemy mentions many ports in the Deccan
- Important seaports:
  - The greatest port was Kalyani on the west Deccan
  - Gandakshela and Ganjam on the east coast were others

### **Cultural contributions**

- The Satavahanas patronized Buddhism and Brahmanism. They built chaityas and viharas
- They also made grants of villages and lands to Buddhist monks
- Vasista Putra Pulamayi repaired the old Amaravati stupa
- Brahmanism was revived by the Satavahanas along with the performance of Ashwamedha and Rajasuya sacrifices
- They also patronized the Prakrit language and literature. Hala's Sattasai is an excellent piece of Prakrit literature

## Foreign invasions of Northwest India

### Bactrians

- Bactrians and Parthia became independent from the Syrian empire in the middle of the third century BCE
- Demetrius, the Greek ruler of Bactria invaded Afghanistan and Punjab and occupied them
- From Taxila, he sent two of his commanders. Appolodotus who conquered the Sindh and marched up to Ujjain and Menander extended his rule up to Mathura and from there he made attempts to capture Pataliputra
- Menander was stopped by the army of Vasumitra, the grandson of Pushyamitra Sunga
- Menander was also known as Milinda and the capital of his kingdom was Sakala (Sialkot)
- Buddhism and his dialogues with the Buddhist monk Nagasena was compiled in Pali work, Milindapanho. He also embraced Buddhism

### Sakas

- The Sakas or the Scythians attacked the Bactria and Parthia and captured them from the Greek rulers
- There were two different groups of Sakas- the Northern Satraps ruling from Taxila and the western satraps ruling over Maharashtra
- The founder of Saka rule in India in the first century BCE was Maues
- His son and successor was Azes I, considered to be the founder of the Vikram era
- Saka rulers of Taxila were overthrown by Parthians

### Kushans

- The Kushanas were a branch of the Yuchi tribe, whose original home was Central Asia. They first came to Bactria displacing the Sakas
- Founder of the Kushana dynasty was Kujula Kadphises or Kadphises I
- He occupied the Kabul valley and issued coins in his name
- His son Wima Kadphises or Kadphises II conquered the whole of northwestern India as far as Mathura
- He issued gold coins with high-sounding titles like the 'Lord of the Whole World'. He was a devotee of Lord Shiva

### Kanishka (78-120 CE)

- Most important ruler of the Kushana dynasty
- He was the founder of the Saka era which starts from 78 CE
- He was not only a great conqueror but also a patron of religion and art

### **Kanishka's conquests**

- He conquered Magadha and extended his power as far as Pataliputra and Bodhgaya
- According to Kalhana, Kanishka invaded Kashmir and occupied it
- He must have conquered the greater part of the Gangetic plain (coins found in places like Mathura, Sravasti, Kausambi and Benares gives an idea)
- He also fought against the Chinese and acquired some territories from them
- Kanishka annexed the territories of Kashgar, Yarkand and Khotan into his empire
- Extension of Kanishka's empire- from Gandhara in the west to Benares in the east, and from Kashmir in the north to Malwa in the south
- His capital was Purushapura. Mathura was another important city in his empire

### **Kanishka and Buddhism**

- Kanishka embraced Buddhism in the early part of his reign
- He was tolerant towards other religions. His coins exhibit the images of not only Buddha but also Greek and Hindu gods
- In the age of Kanishka, the Mahayana Buddhism came into vogue and image worship and rituals developed in Mahayana Buddhism
- He sent missionaries to Central Asia and China for the propagation and also built Buddhist chaityas and viharas at different places
- He also convened the Fourth Buddhist Council which was held at the Kundalavana monastery near Srinagar in Kashmir under the presidentship of Vasumitra
- The Council prepared an authoritative commentary on the Tripitakas and the Mahayana doctrine was given final shape
- He patronised Buddhist scholars like
  - Vasumitra
  - Asvaghosha- a great philosopher, poet and dramatist. He was the author of Buddhacharita
  - Nagarjuna from South India
  - Charaka- the famous physician of ancient India

### **Gandhara Art**

- The best of the Gandhara sculpture was produced during the first and second centuries CE
- It originated during the reign of Indo-Greek rulers
- Real patrons of this school of art were the Sakas and the Kushanas, particularly Kanishka
- Gandhara art was a blend of Indian and Greco-Roman elements
- Specimens have been found in Taxila, Peshawar and other places in northwestern India
- The reliefs depict Buddha's birth, his renunciation and preachings

Salient features:

- Moulding human body in a realistic manner with minute attention to the physical features like muscles, moustache and curly hair
- Thick drapery with large and bold fold lines
- Rich carving, elaborate ornamentation and symbolic expressions
- The main theme was the new form of Buddhism- Mahayanism, and the evolution of an image of Buddha
- The Buddhist stupas erected during this period had Greco-Roman architectural impact with the raised height of the stupa and addition of ornamentation to the structure of the stupa

### **Mathura School of Art**

- It flourished in the first century CE
- The Buddha images exhibit the spiritual feeling in his face which was largely absent in the Gandhara art
- The Mathura school also carved out the images of Siva and Vishnu along with their consorts Parvati and Lakshmi
- The female figures of yakshinis and apsaras of the Mathura school were beautifully carved

### **Successors of Kanishka and end of Kushana rule**

- The successors of Kanishka ruled for another one hundred and fifty years
- Huvishka was the son of Kanishka and he kept the empire intact
- Mathura was an important city under his rule
- Like Kanishka, he was also a patron of Buddhism
- The last important ruler- Vasudeva
- He seems to have been a worshipper of Siva

After Vasudeva, petty Kushan princes ruled for sometime in northwestern India

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## **The Sangam Period**

The Sangam Age constitutes an important chapter in the history of South India. According to Tamil legends, there existed three Sangams (Academy of Tamil poets) popularly called Muchchangam. These Sangams flourished under the royal patronage of the Pandyas.

- The First Sangam, held at then Madurai, was attended by gods and legendary sages but no literary work of this Sangam was available
- The Second Sangam was held at Kapadapuram but all the literary works had perished except Tolkappiyam

- The Third Sangam at Madurai was founded by Moda Thirumaran. It was attended by a large number of poets who produced voluminous literature but only a few survived

### **Sangam Literature**

- The corpus includes Tolkappiyam, Ettuthogai, Pattuppattu, Pathinenkilkanakku, and the two epics- Silappathikaram and Manimegalai.
- Tolkappiyam authored by Tolkappiyar is the earliest of Tamil literature. It is a work on Tamil grammar but it provides information on the political and socio-economic conditions of the Sangam period
- The Ettuthogai or Eight Anthologies consist of eight works- Aingurunooru, Narrinai, Aganaooru, Purananooru, Kuruntogai, Kalittogai, Paripadal and Padirrupattu
- The Pattuppattu or Ten Idylls consist of ten works- Thirumurugarruppadai, Porunararruppadai, Sirupanarruppadai, Perumpanarruppadai, Mullaippattu, Nedunalvada, Madurai Kanji, Kurinjippattu, Pattinappalai and Malaipadukadam
- Both Ettuthogai and Pattuppattu were divided into two main groups- aham (love) and puram (valor)
- Pathinenkilkanakku contains eighteen works mostly dealing with ethics and morals. The most important one among them is Tirukkural authored by Thiruvalluvar
- Silappathigaram written by Elango Adigal and Manimegalai by Sittalai Sattanar also provides valuable information on the Sangam polity and society

### **Other sources**

- Authors- Greek authors like Megasthenes, Strabo, Pliny and Ptolemy mention the commercial contacts between the west and south India
- Inscriptions- The Asokan inscriptions mention the Cholas, Cheras and Pandyas on the south of the Mauryan empire
- The Hathikumbha inscription of Kharvela of Kalinga also mentions about Tamil kingdoms
- The excavations at Arikamedu, Poompuhar, Kodumanal and other places reveal the overseas commercial activities of the Tamils

### **Period of Sangam literature**

- The chronology of the Sangam literature is still disputed
- Silappathigaram as well as the Dipavamsa and Mahavamsa confirms the fact that Gajabahu II of Sri Lanka and Chera Senguttuvan were contemporaries
- On the basis of literary, archaeological and numismatic evidences, the most probable date of the Sangam literature has been fixed between the third century BCE to third century CE

### **Political history**

The Tamil country was ruled by three dynasties namely the Cheras, Cholas and the Pandyas during the Sangam age.

### **Cheras**

- They ruled over parts of modern Kerala
- Their capital was Vanji and their important seaports were Tondi and Musiri
- The Pugalur inscription of the first century CE refers to three generations of Chera rulers
- Padirrupattu also provides information on Chera kings
- Perum Sorru Udhiyan Cheralatan, Imayavaramban Nedum Cheralathan and Cheran Senguttuvan were the famous rulers of this dynasty
- Cheran Senguttuvan belonged to the 2nd century CE. His younger brother was Elango Adigal, the author of Silappathikaram
- He introduced the Pattini cult or the worship of Kannagi as the ideal wife in Tamil Nadu

### **Cholas**

- It extended from modern Tiruchi district to southern Andhra Pradesh
- Capital was first located in Uraiyur and then shifted to Puhar
- Famous king- Karikala
- Pattinappalai portrays his early life and military conquests
- Many Sangam poems mention the Battle of Venni in which he defeated the mighty confederacy consisting of Cheras, Pandyas and eleven minor chieftains
- Vahaipparandalai was another important battle fought by him
- Trade and commerce flourished during his reign period
- He added prosperity to the people by the reclamation of forest lands and bringing them under cultivation
- He also built Kallanai across the river Kaveri and also constructed many irrigation tanks

### **Pandyas**

- The Pandyas ruled over the present day southern Tamil Nadu
- Capital- Madurai
- Earliest kings- Nediyan, Palyagasalai Mudukudumi Peruvaludhi and Mudathirumaran
- Two Neduncheliyans-
  - Aryappadai Kadantha Neduncheliyan (the one who won victories over the Aryans, the one responsible for execution of Kovalan)
  - Talaiyalanganattu Cheruvenra (he who won the battle at Talaiyalanganattu) Neduncheliyan. After the victory of the Battle of Talaiyalanganam, he wore titles like Nakkirar and Mangudi Maruthanar and gained control over the entire Tamil Nadu
- Maduraikkanji written by Mangudi Maruthanar describes the socio-economic condition of the Pandyas
- Last famous Pandyan king- Uggira Peruvaludhi

- Reason for decline- due to invasion of Kalabhras

### **Minor chieftains**

- They played a significant role in the Sangam period
- Among them Pari, Kari, Ori, Nalli, Pegan, Ay and Adiyaman were popular for their philanthropy and patronage of Tamil poets
- They were known as Kadai Yelu Vallalgal

### **Sangam polity**

- Form of government- hereditary monarchy
- The king had also taken the advice of his minister, court-poet and the imperial court or avai and was attended by a number of chiefs and officials
- Titles assumed by kings:
  - Cheras- Vanavaramban, Vanavan, Kuttuvan, Irumporai and Villavar
  - Cholas- Senni, Valavan and Killi
  - Pandyas- Thennavar and Minavar
- Royal emblem of Sangam dynasties:
  - Carp for Pandyas
  - Tiger for Cholas
  - Bow for Cheras
- The king was assisted by a large body of officials who were divided into five councils. They were:
  - Ministers (amaichar)
  - Priests (anthanar)
  - Military commanders (senapati)
  - Envoys (thuthar)
  - Spies (orrrar)
- The military administration was efficiently organized, each ruler had a regular army and their respective Kodimaram (tutelary tree)
- Chief source of state's income- land revenue
- Custom duty was also imposed on foreign trade. The Pattinappalai refers to customs officials employed in the seaport of Puhar
- Booty captured in wars was also a major income to the royal treasury
- Roads and highways were well maintained and guarded night and day to prevent robbery and smuggling

### **Sangam society**

Tolkappiyam refers to a five fold division of lands. The people living here had their own respective occupations and gods.

| Land                   | Chief deity    | Chief occupation                               |
|------------------------|----------------|------------------------------------------------|
| Kurinji (hilly-tracks) | Murugan        | Hunting and honey collection                   |
| Mullai (pastoral)      | Mayon (Vishnu) | Cattle-rearing and dealing with dairy products |
| Marudam (agricultural) | Indira         | Agriculture                                    |
| Neydal (coastal)       | Varunan        | Fishing and salt manufacturing                 |
| Palai (desert)         | Korravai       | Robbery                                        |

Tolkappiyam also refers to four castes namely arasar, anthanar, vanigar and vellalar.

- Ruling class was arasar
- Vanigars carried on trade and commerce
- Vellalars were agriculturists

Other tribal groups- Parathavar, Panar, Eyinar, Kadambar, Maravar and Pulaiyar

Ancient tribes- Thodas, Irulas, Nagas and Vedars

## Religion

- Primary deity was Murugan or Seyon
- He was honored with six abodes known as Arupadai Veedu
- Other gods worshipped- Mayon (Vishnu), Vendan (Indiran), Varunan and Korravai
- The Hero Stone or Nadu Kal worship was significant. It was erected in memory of the bravery shown by the warriors in battle

## Position of women

- Plenty of information in the Sangam literature to trace the position of women
- Women poets like Avvaiyar, Nachchellaiyar, and Kakkapadiniyar flourished in this period and contributed to Tamil literature
- Karpu or Chaste life was considered the highest virtue of women
- Love marriage was a common practice
- Life of widows was miserable
- The practice of Sati was also prevalent in the higher strata of the society
- The class of dancers was patronized by the kings and nobles

## Fine arts

- Poetry, music and dancing were popular among the people then. The arts of music and dancing were highly developed



- The royal courts were crowded with singing bards called Panar and Viraliyar. They were experts on folk songs and folk dances
- A variety of Yazhs and drums are referred to in the Sangam literature
- Dancing was performed by Kanigaiyar
- Koothu was the most popular entertainment of the people

### **Economy of the Sangam Age**

- Chief occupation- agriculture. Rice was the common crop
- Other crops- ragi, sugarcane, cotton, pepper, ginger, turmeric, cinnamon and a variety of fruits
- Jackfruit and pepper were famous in the Chera country
- Paddy was the chief crop in Chola and Pandya countries
- The handicrafts was popular which included weaving, metal works and carpentry, ship building and making of ornaments using beads, stones and ivory
- Spinning and weaving of cotton and silk clothes attained a high quality. There was a great demand in the western world for the cotton clothes woven at Uraiyur
- Both internal and foreign trade was well organized
- Merchants carried the goods on carts and on animal-back from place to place
- Internal trade was mostly based on the barter system
- External trade was carried out between South India and Greek kingdoms
- The port city of Puhar became an emporium of foreign trade. Others ports of commercial activity include Tondi, Musiri, Korkai, Arikamedu and Marakkanam
- The author of Periplus provides the most valuable information on foreign trade
- Plenty of gold and silver coins were issued by the Roman Emperors like Augustus, Tiberius and Nero were found in parts of Tamil Nadu
- Main exports- cotton fabrics, spices like pepper, ginger, cardamom, cinnamon and turmeric, ivory products, pearls and precious stones
- Chief imports- gold, horses and sweet wine

### **End of Sangam Age**

- Towards the end of the third century CE, the Sangam Age slowly witnessed its decline
- The Kalabhras occupied the Tamil country for about two and a half centuries
- Other reasons- Jainism and Buddhism became prominent during this period
- The Pallavas in the northern Tamil Nadu and Pandyas in southern Tamil Nadu drove the Kalabhras out and established their own empire

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## **The Gupta Period**

### **The eminent rulers of the Gupta empire:**

- Chandragupta I (320-335 or 340 CE)
- Samudragupta (nearly 340-380 CE)
- Ramagupta
- Chandragupta II (nearly 380-413 or 415 CE)
- Kumaragupta (near about 415-55 CE)
- Skandagupta (455-467 CE)
- Purugupta (467-469 CE)
- Buddhagupta (477 to nearly 500 CE)

### **Sources**

- Devichandraguptam and the Mudhrarakshasam written by Visakhadutta- provide information regarding the rise of Guptas
- The Chinese traveler Fahein, who visited India during the reign of Chandragupta II, has left a valuable account of the social, economic and religious conditions of the Gupta empire

### **Inscriptions**

- Mehrauli Iron Pillar Inscription refers to the achievements of Chandragupta I
- Allahabad Pillar Inscription- important source for the reign of Samudragupta which describes his personality and achievements. This inscription is engraved on Asokan pillar
- It is written in classical Sanskrit, using the Nagari script
- It consists of 33 lines composed by Harisena which describes the circumstances of Samudragupta's accession, his military campaigns in north India and the Deccan, his relationship with other contemporary rulers, and his accomplishments as a poet and scholar
- Coins issued by Gupta kings contain legends and figures. And provide interesting details about the titles and sacrifices performed by the Gupta monarchs

### **Chandragupta I (320- 330 CE)**

- The founder of the Gupta dynasty was Sri Gupta
- He was succeeded by Ghatotkacha. These two were called Maharajas
- Chandragupta I was the first to be called Maharajadhiraja (the great king of kings)
- He strengthened his position by a matrimonial alliance with the Licchavis. He married Kumaradevi, a princess of that family
- The Mehrauli Iron Pillar inscription mentions his extensive conquests
- Founder of the Gupta era which starts with his accession in 320 CE

### **Samudragupta (320-380 CE)**

- The greatest of the rulers of the Gupta dynasty
- Allahabad pillar provides a detailed account of his reign
- It refers to three stages in his military campaign:
  - Against some rulers of north India- Samudragupta defeated Achyuta (probably a Naga ruler) and Nagasena (belonged to the Kota family). Gained complete mastery over the upper Gangetic valley
  - His famous Dakshinapatha expedition against South Indian rulers- Allahabad pillar inscription mentions that Samudragupta defeated twelve rulers in his South Indian expedition. He defeated the rulers but gave them back their kingdoms and only insisted on them to acknowledge his suzerainty
  - A second campaign against some other rulers of North India to eliminate his remaining north Indian rivals (Nagadatta, Rudradev, Nagasena, Achyuta, Nandin etc)
    - After these military conquests, Samudragupta performed the Asvamedha sacrifices
    - He issued gold and silver coins with the legend 'Restorer of the Asvamedha'
    - Samudragupta was hailed as 'Indian Napoleon' because of his military achievements

### **Extent of Samudragupta's Empire**

- After these conquests, Samudragupta's rule extended over the upper Gangetic valley, the greater part of modern UP, a portion of central India and the southwestern part of Bengal
- Southern influence- the Saka and Kushana principalities on the west and northwest
- Kingdoms on the east coast of the Deccan, as far as the Pallava kingdom, acknowledged his suzerainty

### **Estimate of Samudragupta**

#### **Accomplishments**

- Military achievements- The Allahabad Pillar Inscription speaks of his magnanimity to his foes, his polished intellect, his poetic skill and his proficiency in music- his image depicting him with Veena is found in the coins issued by him
- It calls him Kaviraja because of his ability in composing verses
- He also patronized many poets and scholars, one of whom was Harisena. He also promoted Sanskrit literature and learning
- He was an ardent follower of Vaishnavism but was tolerant of other creeds. He evinced keen interest in Buddhism and was the patron of the great Buddhist scholar Vasubandhu

### **Chandragupta II (380-415 CE)**

- He also called himself Vikramaditya
- He extended the Gupta empire by his own conquests by a judicious combination of the policy of diplomacy and warfare
- Through matrimonial alliances he strengthened his political power
  - He married Kuberanaga, a Naga princess of central India
  - He gave his daughter Prabhavati in marriage to the Vakataka prince Rudrasena II (Vakatakas occupied a geographically strategic position in the Deccan)
  - This alliance helped him to campaign in western India against the Sakas
- Conquest of Western India- war against the Saka satraps of western India
  - Rudrasimha III, the last ruler of the Saka satrap was defeated, dethroned and killed and western Malwa and the Kathiawar Peninsula were annexed into the Gupta empire
  - After this victory he performed the horse sacrifice and assumed the title Sakari, meaning, 'destroyer of Sakas'

### **Benefits of conquest of western India**

- The western boundary of the Empire reached to the Arabian Sea gaining access to Broach, Sopara, Cambay and other sea ports
- To control trade with the western countries
- Ujjain became an important commercial city and alternative capital of the Guptas
- Trade with Roman empire- the fine cotton clothes of Bengal, Indigo from Bihar, silk from Benares, the scents from Himalayas and the sandal and spices from the south were brought to these ports and western traders poured Roman gold into India in return for Indian products

### **Other conquests**

- Chandragupta II defeated a confederacy of enemy chiefs in Vanga
- He also crossed the river Sindh and conquered Bactria. The Kushanas were subdued by him. And the empire extended in the west as far as western Malwa, Gujarat and Kathiawar
- In the northwest it extended beyond the Hindukush up to Bactria
- In the east, it included even eastern Bengal and in the south, the Narmada river formed the boundary

### **Fa Hien's visit**

- Chinese pilgrim, who visited India during the reign of Chandragupta II
- Out of his nine years stay in India, he spent six years in the Gupta empire
- He came to India by the land route and returned by the sea route, visiting on the way Ceylon and Java
- The main purpose of his visit- primarily religious, and see the land of the Buddha and to collect Buddhist manuscripts from India

- He stayed in Pataliputra for three years studying Sanskrit and copying Buddhist texts
- He provided valuable information on the religious, social and economic condition of the Gupta empire
- He mentioned about the flourishing condition of northwestern India but he referred the Gangetic valley as the 'Land of Brahmanism'
- Fahein mentions the unsatisfactory state of some of the Buddhist holy places like Kapilavastu and Kushinagar. According to him, the economic condition of the empire was prosperous
- Although his account is valuable in many respects, he did not mention the name of Chandragupta II. He was not interested in political affairs. His interest was primarily religion

### **Estimate of Chandragupta II**

- The power and glory of the Gupta empire reached its peak
- He also contributed to the general cultural progress of the age and patronized great literary figures like Kalidasa. He promoted artistic activity. It is one of the reason why Gupta period is generally referred to as the Golden Age

### **Successors of Chandragupta II**

- Kumaragupta- son and successor of Chandragupta II
  - Reign was marked by peace and prosperity
  - He issued a number of coins and his inscriptions are found all over the Gupta empire
  - He also performed an ashwamedha sacrifice
  - Laid the foundation of the Nalanda university which emerged as an institution of international reputation
  - The end of his reign witnessed the defeat of the Gupta army by a powerful wealthy tribe called the Pushyamitras. A branch of the Huns from Central Asia made attempts to cross the Hindukush mountains and invade India
- Skandagupta- His successor faced the Hun invasion, fought successfully against the Huns and saved the empire
- Decline of gupta power- after Skandagupta's death, many of his successors like Purugupta, Narasimhagupta, Buddhagupta and Baladitya could not save the Gupta empire from the Huns

Gupta power totally disappeared due to the Hun invasions and later by the rise of Yasodharman in Malwa.

### **Gupta administration**

- Various inscriptions mentioned about the titles that the Gupta kings assumed-
  - Parama Bhattaraka
  - Maharajadhiraja
  - Parameswara
  - Smrat
  - Chakravartin
- The king was assisted in his administration by a council consisting of a chief minister, a Senapati or commander-in-chief of the army and other important officials
- A high official called Sandivigraha- most probably minister for foreign affairs
- Kumaramatyas and Ayuktas- The king maintained a close contact in the provincial administration through them
- Bhuktis- provinces in the Gupta empire. Bhuktis were subdivided into Vishyas or districts governed by Vishyapatis
- Uparikas- provincial governors. They were mostly chosen from among the princes
- Nagara Sresthis- officers looking after the city administration
- The villages in the district were under the control of the Gramikas
- Fa Hien's account of the Gupta administration appreciated the efficiency of the Guptas
  - Administration as mild and benevolent, more liberal than that of the Mauryas
  - No restrictions on people's movements and they enjoyed personal freedom
  - No state interference in the individual's life
  - Punishments were not severe. Imposing a fine was a common punishment
  - No spy system
  - Roads were kept safe for travelers, and there was no fear of thieves
  - People were generally prosperous and the crimes were negligible

### **Social life**

Caste system: During the Gupta period, the caste system became rigid. The Brahmins occupied the top ladder of the society.

- They were given enormous gifts by the rulers as well as other wealthy people
- The practice of untouchability had slowly begun. Fahein mentions that Chandalas were segregated from the society and their condition was miserable

The position of women: became miserable

- Prohibited from studying the religious texts like the Puranas
- The practice of Swayamvara was given up
- The Manusmriti suggested the early marriage for girls

Religion: Brahmanism reigned supreme with two branches- Vaishnavism and Shaivism

- Most of the Gupta kings were Vaishnavites. They performed ashwamedha sacrifices
- Religious literature like the Puranas was composed during this period

- The progress of Brahmanism led to the neglect of Buddhism and Jainism. Fahein refers to the decline of Buddhism in the Gangetic valley. But a few Buddhist scholars like Vasubandu were patronized by Gupta kings
- In western and southern India, Jainism flourished
- The great Jain Council was held at Vallabhi during this period and the Jain Canon of the Svetambaras was written

## **Art and Culture**

- The Gupta period witnessed tremendous progress in the field of art, science and literature and so has been called "a golden age". A few scholars even call this period a period of renaissance
- Temple style: both the Nagara and Dravidian styles of art evolved during this period (most of the architecture of this period had been lost due to foreign invasions like that of the Huns)

Important specimen of the Gupta art:

- The temple at Deogarh, near Jhansi
- Sculptures in the temple at Garhwas near Allahabad
- There was no influence of Gandhara style. But the beautiful statue of standing Buddha at Mathura reveals a little Greek style
- The Buddha statue unearthed at Sarnath
- The Bhitari monolithic pillar of Skandagupta
- Metallurgy was also progressed
- The craftsmen were efficient in the art of casting metal statues and pillars
- The gigantic copper statue of Buddha: was about seven and a half feet height and nearly a ton weight
- The Delhi Iron Pillar- still free from rust
- The paintings of the Gupta period are seen at Bagh caves near Gwalior
- The mural paintings of Ajanta mostly illustrate the life of the Buddha as depicted in the Jataka stories
- The paintings at Sigiriya in Sri Lanka were highly influenced by the Ajanta style

## **Gupta coinage**

- Samudragupta issued eight types of gold coins
- The legends on them throw much light on the achievements of that marvelous king
- The figures inscribed on them are illustrative of the skill and greatness of Gupta numismatic art
- Chandragupta II and his successors had also issued gold, silver and copper coins of different varieties

## **Literature**

- The Sanskrit language became prominent during the Gupta period. Numerous works in classical Sanskrit came to be written in the forms of epic, lyrics, drama and prose
- Nagari script had evolved from the Brahmi script
- Samudragupta patronized a number of scholars including Harisena and he himself was a great poet
- The court of Chandragupta II was adorned by the celebrated Navratnas
- Kalidasa- His masterpiece was the Sanskrit drama Shakuntala, considered one among the 'hundred best books of the world'
- Other plays- Malavikagnimitra and Vikramorvasiya
- Epics- Raghuvamsa and Kumarasambhava
- Lyrics- Ritusamhara and Meghaduta
- Visakhadutta was the author of two Sanskrit dramas, Mudrarakshasa and Devichandraguptam
- Sudraka- wrote the book Mrichakatika, rich in humor and pathos
- Bharavi's Kiratarjuniya is the story of the conflict between Arjuna and Siva
- Dandin was the author of Kavyadarsa and Dasakumaracharita
- Vasavadatta written by Subhandhu
- The Panchatantra stories were composed by Vishnusarma
- The Buddhist author Amarasimha compiled a lexicon called Amarakosa
- The Puranas in their present form were composed during this period. There are eighteen Puranas. The most important among them are the Bhagavatha, Vishnu, Vayu and Matsya Puranas
- The Mahabharata and the Ramayana were given final touches and written in the present form during this period

## Science

Field of mathematics, astronomy and astrology

- Aryabhata: a great mathematician and astronomer, wrote the book Aryabhatiya in 499 CE. It deals with mathematics and astronomy
- It explains scientifically the occurrence of solar and lunar eclipses
- Aryabhata was the first to declare that the earth was spherical in shape and that it rotates on its own axis
- Varahamihira: composed Pancha Siddhantika, the five astronomical systems
- Brihadsamhita is a great work by him in Sanskrit literature which deals with a variety of subjects like astronomy, astrology, geography, architecture, weather, animals, marriage and omens
- His Brihadjataka is a standard work on astrology

Field of medicine

- Vagbhata: was the last of the great medical trio of ancient India
- He was the author of Ashtangasamgraha (summary of the eight branches of medicine)



- Charaka and Susruta were two great scholars that lived before the Gupta age
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## Age Of Harshavardhana (606-647 CE)

### Sources

Harshavardhana's Reign was established in the beginning of the 7th century CE.

Chief sources:

- Harshacharita written by Bana (court poet of Harsha)
- Travel accounts of Hiuen Tsang, the Chinese traveler who visited India in the 7th century CE
- The dramas written by Harsha, namely Ratnavali, Nagananda and Priyadarshika
- The Madhuben plate inscription and the Sonpat inscription are helpful to know the ecology of Harsha
- The Banskhera inscription contains the signature of Harsha, a larger kingdom in north India

### Early life of Harsha

- The founder of the family of Harsha was Pushyabhuti
- Pushyabhutis:
  - The feudatories of the Guptas, called themselves Vardhanas
  - They assumed independence after the Hun invasions
  - Prabhakarvardhana was the first important king of Pushyabhuti dynasty. His capital was Thaneswar, north of Delhi
  - He assumed the title Maharajadhiraja and Parama Bhattaraka
- His elder son was Rajyavardhana and after his death, Harshavardhana succeeded his brother at Thaneswar

### Harsha's Military conquests

- The first expedition made him the most powerful ruler of north India by driving out Sasanka from Kannauj and making Kanauj his new capital
- This Harsha fought against Dhruvasena II of Vallabhi and defeated him
- The most important military campaign: against Pulakesin II, the western Chalukya ruler
- Both the accounts of Hiuen Tsang and the inscriptions of Pulakesin II provide the details of this campaign
- Aihole inscription of Pulakesin II mentions the defeat of Harsha by Pulakesin, who after this achievement assumed the title Paramesvara. Hiuen Tsang's accounts also confirm the victory of Pulakesin

Harsha's campaign that led to hold over the whole of north India

- Campaign against the ruler of Sindh
- Nepal had accepted Harsha's overlordship
- Control over Kashmir and its ruler sent tributes to him
- He also maintained cordial relationships with Bhaskaravarman, the ruler of Assam
- His last military campaign against the kingdom of Kalinga in Orissa was also a success
- The regions of modern Rajasthan, Punjab, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Orissa were under his direct control
- Kashmir, Sindh, Vallabhi and Kamarupa acknowledged his sovereignty

### **Harsha and Buddhism**

- In his early life, Harsha was a devout Shaiva but later he became an ardent Hinayana Buddhist
- Hiuen Tsang converted him to Mahayana Buddhism
- Harsha prohibited the use of animal food in his kingdom and punished those who killed living beings
- He erected thousands of stupas and monasteries at the sacred Buddhist sites. He brought the Buddhist monks together frequently to discuss and examine the Buddhist doctrines
- He also established resthouses for travelers all over his kingdom
- Once in five years, he convened a gathering of representatives of all religions and honored them with gifts and costly presents

### **Kannauj Assembly**

- A religious assembly organized by Harsha at Kannauj to honor the Chinese pilgrim Hiuen Tsang that went on continuously for 23 days
- He invited representatives of all religious sects and was attended by kings, scholars from the Nalanda University, Hinayanists and Mahayanists, Brahmins and Jains
- Hiuen Tsang explained the values of Mahayana doctrine and established its superiority over others. However, violence broke out and there was also an attempt on the life of Harsha
- Soon, it was brought under control and the guilty were punished
- On the final day of the assembly, Hiuen Tsang was honored with costly presents

### **Allahabad Conference**

- Hiuen Tsang mentioned about the conference in his account
- It was one among the conferences that was routinely convened by Harsha once every five years
- Harsha gave away his enormous wealth as gifts to the members of all religious sects

- According to Hiuen Tsang, Harsha was so lavish that he emptied the treasury and even gave away the clothes and jewels he was wearing
- His statement might be one of admiring exaggeration

### **Harsha's administration**

- The administration of Harsha was organized on the same lines as that of the Guptas
- Hiuen Tsang gives a detailed picture about this
- The king: just in his administration and was punctual in discharging his duties. He made frequent visits of inspection throughout his dominion
- Taxation: was also light and forced labor was also rare. One sixth of the produce was collected as land tax
- Cruel punishments of the Mauryan period continued in the times of Harsha
- Harsha's army consisted of the traditional four divisions- foot, horse, chariot and elephant. The number of cavalry and the elephants were much more than that of the Mauryan army
- Salient features of Harsha's administration: The maintenance of public records
- The archive of the period was known as Nilopitu which recorded both good and bad events and it was under the control of special officers

### **Society and Economy under Harsha**

Both Bana and Hiuen Tsang portray social life in the times of Harsha.

Caste system:

- Fourfold division of society- Brahmins, Kshatriyas, Vysyas and Sudras
- The Brahmins were the privileged section of the society and were given land grants by the kings
- Kshatriyas were the ruling class
- Vysyas were mainly traders
- Hiuen Tsang mentions that the Sudras practiced agriculture mostly
- There existed many sub castes

Position of women:

- Not satisfactory. The institution of Swayamvara had declined
- Remarriage of widows was not permitted, particularly among the higher castes
- The system of dowry had become common
- Practice of sati was also prevalent

Hiuen Tsang mentions three ways for the disposal of the dead- cremation, water burial and exposure in the woods

#### Trade and commerce:

- Evident from the decline of trade centres, less number of coins, and slow activities of merchant guilds shows sharp economic decline as compared to the economy of the Gupta period
- The decline of trade in turn affected the handicrafts industry and agriculture
- Rise of self-sufficient economy: Since there was no large scale demand for goods, the farmers began to produce only in a limited way

#### Cultural progress

- The art and architecture of Harsha's period mostly followed the Gupta style
- Hiuen Tsang describes the glory of the monastery with many storeys built by Harsha at Nalanda
- He also speaks of a copper statue of Buddha with eight feet in height
- The brick temple of Lakshmana at Sirpur belongs to the period of Harsha
- He was a great patron of learning. Banabhatta adorned his royal court
- He wrote Harshacharita and Kadambari
- Other literary figures in Harsha's court were Matanga Divakara and the famous Barthrihari, who was a poet, philosopher and grammarian
- Harsha himself authored three plays- Ratnavali, Priyadarsika and Nagananda
- Harsha patronized the Nalanda university which attained international reputation as a centre of learning during his reign
- Hiuen Tsang visited the Nalanda university and remained a student for some time and also gave valuable account of it

#### Nalanda University

- The term Nalanda means "giver of knowledge"
- It was founded by Kumaragupta I during the Gupta period
- It was an institution of advanced learning and research
- It was patronized by his successors and later by Harsha
- The professors of the university, called panditas, were Dingnaga, Dharmapala, Sthiramati and Silabhadra
- Dharmapala was a native of Kanchipuram and he became the head of the Nalanda university
- It was a residential university and education was free including boarding and lodging
- It was maintained with the revenue derived from 100 to 200 villages endowed by different rulers
- Subjects taught:
  - Though it was a Mahayana university, different religious subjects like the Vedas, Hinayana doctrine, Sankhya and Yoga philosophies were also taught
  - In addition to that, general subjects like logic, grammar, astronomy, medicine and art were in the syllabus

- Admission was made by means of an entrance examination which was difficult
  - Discipline was very strict
  - Discussion played an important part and the medium of instruction was Sanskrit
  - Recent archaeological excavations:
    - Confirms the accounts given by Chinese pilgrims
    - Says, it had numerous classrooms and a hostel attached to it
  - According to Itsing, the Chinese pilgrim, there were 3000 students on its rolls. It had an observatory and a great library housed in three buildings
  - It attracted scholars from various parts of the world
  - It was an institution of advanced learning and research
- 

## South Indian Kingdoms : Pallavas

### Background

Decline of the Sangam Age in the Tamil country was followed by the Kalabhra rule which lasted for about 250 years. Thereafter, the Pallavas established their kingdom in Tondaimandalam with its capital at Kanchipuram. In the beginning of the tenth century CE, Tondaimandalam was captured and annexed by the Imperial Cholas.

### Origin of the Pallavas

Different views- none supported by adequate evidences

- They were equated with the Parthians, the foreigners who ruled western India
- Pallavas were a branch of the Brahmin royal dynasty of the Vakatakas of the Deccan
- Pallavas with the descendants of the Chola prince and a Naga princess whose native was the island of Manipallavam

Widely accepted: Pallavas were the natives of Tondaimandalam. They are also identical with the Pulindas mentioned in the inscriptions of Asoka

- They were feudatories of Satavahanas and after the fall of the Satavahanas in the third century CE, they became independent
- Because of their Satavahana connections, they issued their earliest inscriptions in Prakrit and Sanskrit and also patronized Brahmanism

### Political history

The early Pallava rulers (250-350 CE)

- Issued their charters in Prakrit
- Important among them were Sivaskandavarman and Vijayaskandavarman

The second line of Pallava rulers (350-550 CE)

- Issued their charters in Sanskrit
- The most important ruler was Vishnugopa who was defeated by Samudragupta during his South Indian expedition

The rulers of the third line (575 CE- ninth century: their ultimate fall)

- Issued their charters both in Sanskrit and Tamil
- Simhavishnu was the first ruler of this line
- He destroyed the Kalabhras and firmly established the Pallava rule in Tondaimandalam
- He also defeated the Cholas and extended the Pallava territory up to the river Kaveri

Other great Pallava rulers of this line:

Mahendravarman I, Narasimhavarman I and Narasimhavarman II

### **Mahendravarman I (600-630 CE)**

- Period of Pallava- Chalukya conflict
- Pulakesin II marched against the Pallavas and captured the northern part of their kingdom, a Pallava inscription refers to the victory of Mahendravarman I at Pullalur, but he was not able to recover the lost territory
- A follower of Jainism in the early part of his career, later converted to Shaivism by the influence of the Saiva saint, Thirunavukkarasar alias Appar. He built a Saiva temple at Tiruvadi
- Titles he assumed: Gunabhara, Satyasandha, Chattakari (builder of temples) Chitrakarapuli, Vichitrachitta and Mattavilasa
- He was a great builder of cave temples. His rock cut temples are found in a number of places like Vallam, Pallavaram, Mandagapattu and Tiruchirappalli
- The Mandagapattu inscription hails him as Vichitrachitta who constructed a temple for Brahma, Vishnu and Siva without the use of bricks, timber, metal and mortar
- He had also authored the Sanskrit work Mattavilasa Prahasanam
- Painting: He was titled Chitrakarapuli, and also regarded as an expert in music. The music inscription at Kudumiyanmalai is ascribed to him

### **Narasimhavarman I (630-668 CE)**

Was also known as Mamalla, which means 'great wrestler'

Achievements:

- He got victorious over Pulakesin II in the Battle of Manimangalam near Kanchi and is mentioned in Kuram copper plates
- The Pallava army under General Paranjothi entered Chalukya territory, captured and destroyed the capital city of Vatapi. Narasimhavarman I assumed the title 'Vatapikonda'. He regained the lost territory

- His naval expedition to Sri Lanka. He restored the throne to his friend and Sri Lankan prince Manavarma
- During his reign, Hiuen Tsang visited the Pallava capital Kanchipuram
- Narasimhavarman I was the founder of Mamallapuram and the monolithic rathas were erected during his reign

### **Narasimhavarman II or Rajasimha (695-722 CE)**

- Narasimhavarman I was succeeded by Mahendravarman II and Parameswara Varman I and the Pallava- Chalukya conflict continued during their reign
- Narasimhavarman II evinced more interest in developing art and architecture. The Shore Temple at Mamallapuram and the Kailasanatha temple at Kanchipuram were built in this period
- The famous Sanskrit scholar Dandin is said to have adorned his court
- Rajasimha assumed titles like Sankarabhakta, Vadhyavidyadhara and Agamapriya
- He was succeeded by Parameswaravarman II and Nandivarman II
- The Pallava rule lasted till the end of the ninth century CE
- End of Pallava dynasty: Chola king Aditya I defeated the last Pallava ruler Aparajita and seized the Kanchi region

### **Administration of the Pallavas**

- Well organized administrative system
- The Pallava state was divided into Kottams. And was administered by officers appointed by the king
- The king was at the centre of administration and was the foundation of justice
- He maintained a well-trained army
- He provided land-grants to the temples known as Devadhana and also to the Brahmans known as Brahmadeya
- Irrigation facility: A number of irrigation tanks were dug by the Pallava kings
- The irrigation tanks at Mahendravadi and Mamandoor were dug during the reign of Mahendravarman I
- Sabhas were village assemblies and their committees maintained records of all village lands, looked after local affairs and managed temples

### **Society under the Pallavas**

- The caste system became rigid. The Brahmins occupied a high place in the society
- They were given land-grants by the kings and nobles. They were also given the responsibility of looking after the temples
- The Pallava period also witnessed the rise of Saivism and Vaishnavism (The Saiva Nayanars and Vaishnava Alvars contributed to it- Bhakti Movement) and also the decline of Buddhism and Jainism

- They composed their hymns in the Tamil language. The construction of temples by the Pallava kings paved the way for the spread of these two religions

### **Education and literature**

- Their capital Kanchi was an ancient centre of learning. The Ghatika at Kanchi was popular
- Mayurasarman, the founder of the Kadamba dynasty, studied Vedas at Kanchi
- Dingnaga, a Buddhist writer came to study at Kanchi
- Dharmapala, who later became the Head of the Nalanda University, belonged to Kanchi
- Bharavi, the great Sanskrit scholar lived in the time of Simhavishnu
- Dandin, another Sanskrit writer adorned the court of Narasimhavarman II
- Mahendravarman I composed the Sanskrit play Mattavilasaprahasanam
- Tamil literature had also developed. The Nayanars and Alvars composed religious hymns in Tamil
- The Devaram composed by Nayanars and the Nalayradivyaprabandam composed by Alvars
- Perundevanar translated the Mahabharata as Bharatavenba in Tamil was patronized by Nandivarman II
- Nandikkalambagam was another important work- author unknown
- Music and dance also developed during this period

### **Pallava art and architecture**

It was a great age of temple building. They introduced the art of excavating temples from the rock.

In fact, the Dravidian style of temple architecture began with the Pallava rule. (From the cave temples to monolithic rathas and culminated in structural temples)

The development of temple architecture under the Pallavas: four stages

- Mahendravarman I introduced the rock-cut temples. Seen at places like Mandagappattu, Mahendravadi, Mamandur, Dalavanur, Tiruchirapalli, Vallam, Seeyamangalam and Tirukalukundram
- Monolithic rathas and Mandapas found at Mamallapuram- by Narasimhavarman I
  - The five rathas, popularly called as the Pancha Pandava rathas, signifies five different styles of temple architecture
  - The Mandapas contain beautiful sculptures on its walls. The most popular are Mahisasuramardini Mandapa. Tirumurthi Mandapam and Varaha Mandapam
- Rajasimha introduced the structural temples. These temples were built by using the soft sand rocks. Eg- The Kailasanatha temple at Kanchi and the Shore temple at Mamallapuram
- The last stage represented by structural temples built by the later Pallavas



- The Vaikunda Perumal temple, Mukteeswara temple and Matagenswara temples at Kanchipuram belong to this stage of architecture

### **Sculptural development**

- Open Art Gallery at Mamallapuram remains an important monument bearing the sculptural beauty of this period
- The Descent of the Ganges or the Penance of Arjuna is called a fresco painting in stone
- These sculptures contain the minute details as well as the different theme such as the figures of lice-picking monkeys, elephants of huge size and the figure of the 'ascetic cat'

### **Fine Arts**

- Music, dance and painting had also developed under the patronage of the Pallavas
  - Inscriptions:
    - The Mamandur inscription- note on the notation of vocal music
    - The Kudumianmalai inscription- referred to musical notes and instruments
  - The Alvars and Nayanars composed their hymns in various musical notes
  - Dance and drama also developed during this period. The sculptures of this period depict many dancing postures
  - The Sittannavasal paintings belonged to this period
  - The commentary called Dakshinchitta was compiled during the reign of Mahendravarman I, who had the title Chittikkarapuli
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## **South Indian Kingdoms : Chalukyas and Rashtrakutas**

- The Western Chalukyas ruled over an extensive area in the Deccan for about two centuries after which the Rashtrakutas became powerful
- Offshoot: Eastern Chalukyas of Vengi and the Chalukyas of Kalyani
- Founder: Pulakesin I, with Vatapi or Badami as its capital

### **Pulakesin II (608- 642 CE)**

The most important ruler. The Aihole inscription issued by him gives the details of his reign.

Achievements:

- He fought with Kadambas of Banavasi and the Gangas of Mysore and established his suzerainty
- The Ganga ruler, Durvinita, accepted his overlordship and even gave his daughter in marriage to him
- Defeat of Harshavardhana on the banks of the river Narmada. He put a check to the ambition of Harsha to conquer the south

- Expedition against the Pallavas- at first Pulakesin II emerged victorious
- Battle of Vatapi- he suffered a humiliating defeat at the hands of Narasimhavarman I near Kanchi in 642 (Chalukya capital Vatapi was captured and destroyed by the Pallavas)
- The most important event- visit of Hiuen Tsang to his kingdom
- The successor of Pulakesin II- Vikramaditya who consolidated the Chalukya kingdom and plundered the Pallava capital, Kanchi
- The last of the ruler- Kirtivarman II. He was defeated by Dantidurga, the founder of the Rashtrakuta dynasty

### **Administration and Social life under the Chalukyas**

- The administration was highly centralized unlike that of the Pallavas and the Cholas
- Village autonomy was absent
- They had great maritime power, also had a small standing army
- The Badami Chalukyas were Brahmanical Hindus but they gave respect to other religions. Eg- Ravikirti, the court poet of Pulakesin II, who composed the Aihole inscription was a Jain
- Importance was given to Vedic rites and rituals. Pulakesin I performed the Asvamedha sacrifice
- Hiuen Tsang mentioned about the decline of Buddhism and progress of Jainism in western Deccan

### **Art and architecture**

- The Chalukyas were great patrons of art
- Temple style- vesara style. However, the vesara style reached its culmination only under the Rashtrakutas and the Hoysalas
- The structural temples- at Aihole, Badami and Pattadakal
- Cave temple architecture- Ajanta, Ellora and Nasik
- The best specimens of Chalukya paintings can be seen in the Badami cave temple and in the Ajanta caves

### **Division of Chalukya temples- two stages**

- First stage represented by the temples at Aihole and Badami
- Important temples found at Aihole (among the seventy)
  - Ladh Khan temple is a low, flat-roofed structure consisting of a pillared hall
  - Durga temple resembles a Buddha Chaitya
  - Huchimalligudi temple
  - The Jain temple at Meguti
- Temples at Badami- Muktheeswarar temple and the Melagutti Sivalaya
- The second stage: represented by the temples at Pattadakal
- There are ten temples here- four in the northern style and six in the Dravidian style

- The Virupaksha temple built by one of the queens of Vikramaditya II is built on the model of the Kailasanatha temple at Kanchipuram

### **Rashtrakutas (755-975 CE)**

- The Rashtrakutas were of Kannada origin and Kannada language was their mother tongue
- Founder- Dantidurga. He defeated the Gurjaras and captured Malwa from them
- Then he annexed the Chalukya kingdom by defeating Kirtivarman II
- Successor- Krishna. He defeated the Gangas and the eastern Chalukyas of Vengi
- He built the magnificent rock-cut monolithic Kailasa temple at Ellora
- Govinda III- the next important king of this dynasty who achieved victories over north Indian kingdoms
- His successor was Amoghavarsha (815-880 CE) whose reign was popular for the cultural development
- He was a follower of Jainism and was also a patron of letters and wrote the famous Kannada work, Kavirajamarga. Jinasena was his chief preceptor
- He had also built the Rashtrakuta capital, the city of Malkhed or Manyakheda
- Krishna III (936-968 CE)- one of the successors of Amoghavarsha I
- Expedition-
  - He marched against the Cholas and defeated them at Thakkolam and also captured Tanjore
  - He also occupied Rameswaram for sometime
- He built several temples in the conquered territories including the Krishneswara temple at Rameswaram
- Throughout his reign he possessed the Tondaimandalam region including the capital Kanchi
- After his death, the power of the Rashtrakutas declined

### **Administration**

- The Rashtrakuta empire was divided into several provinces called Rashtras under the control of rashtrapati
- They were further divided into visayas or districts governed by vishayapatis
- The next subdivision was bhukti consisting of 50 to 70 villages under the control of bhogapathi
- These officers were directly appointed by the central government
- The village administration was carried on by the village headmen
- However, the village assemblies played a significant role in the village administration

### **Society and Economy**

- The Hindu sects of Vaishnavism and Shaivism flourished. Yet, there was a progress of Jainism under the patronage of Rashtrakuta kings and officers

- Almost one third of the population of the Deccan were Jains
- Some prosperous Buddhist settlements at places like Kanheri, Sholapur and Dharwar
- The economy was also in a flourishing condition. There was an active commerce between the Deccan and the Arabs
- The Rashtrakuta kings promoted the Arab trade by maintaining friendship with them

### **Cultural contributions**

- The Rashtrakutas widely patronized the Sanskrit literature
- Scholars- Trivikrama wrote Nalachampu and the Kavirahasya was composed by Halayudha during the reign of Krishna III
- The Jain literature flourished under the patronage of the Rashtrakutas
- Amoghavarsha I, who was a Jain, patronized many Jain scholars. His teacher Jinasena composed Parsva Budaya, a biography of Parswa in verses
- Gunabhadra wrote the Adipurana, the life stories of various Jain saints
- Sakatayana wrote the grammar work called Amogha Vritti
- The great mathematician of this period, Viracharya was the author of Ganitasaram
- Rashtrakutas period saw the beginning of Kannada literature
- Amoghavarsha's Kavirajamarga was the first poetic work in Kannada language
- Pampa was the greatest of the Kannada poets. His famous work was Vikramasenavijaya
- Ponna was another famous Kannada poet and he wrote Santipurana

### **Art and architecture**

- The art and architecture of the Rashtrakutas were found at Ellora and Elephanta
- Most remarkable temple- Kailasa temple at Ellora, which was excavated during the reign of Krishna I
- It is carved out of a massive block of rock 200 feet long, and 100 feet in breadth and height
- The temple consists of four parts- the main shrine, the entrance gateway, an intermediate shrine for Nandi and mandapa surrounding the courtyard
- The temple stands on a lofty plinth 25 feet high
- In the interior of the temple there is a pillared hall which has sixteen square pillars
- The sculpture of the Goddess Durga is shown as slaying the Buffalo demon
- In another sculpture Ravana was making attempts to lift Mount Kailasa, the abode of Siva
- The scenes of Ramayana were also depicted on the walls
- The general characteristics of the Kailasa temple are more Dravidian
- Elephanta- an island near Bombay. It was originally called Sripuri
- How it got called Elephanta- the Portuguese after seeing the large figure of an elephant named it Elephanta
- There is close similarity between the sculptures at Ellora and Elephanta
- At the entrance to the sanctum there are huge figures of Dwarapalakas

- In the walls of the prakara around the sanctum there are niches containing the images of Shiva in various forms- Nataraja, Ganagadhara, Ardhanarishwara and Somaskanda
  - Trimurthi- the most imposing figure of this temple which is six metre high sculpture
  - It is said to represent the three aspects of Shiva as Creator, Preserver and Destroyer
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## Imperial Cholas

- Prominence in the 9th century CE
- Capital- Tanjore
- Also known as the Imperial Cholas. They established an empire comprising the major portion of South India and also extended their sway in Sri Lanka and the Malay peninsula
- Founder- Vijayalaya
- He captured Tanjore from Muttaraiyars in 815 CE and built a temple for Durga

### Parantaka I

- One of the important early Chola rulers
- He defeated the Pandyas and the ruler of Ceylon
- Battle of Takkolam- Parantaka got defeated by the Rashtrakutas
- Being a great builder of temples, he provided the vimana of the famous Nataraja temple at Chidambaram with a golden roof
- Uthiramerur inscriptions that give a detailed account of the village administration under the Cholas belong to his reign

### Rajaraja I (985-1014 CE)

- Cholas regained their supremacy under him and his son Rajendra I
- Military conquests:
  - The defeat of the Chera ruler Bhaskararavivarman in the naval battle of Kandalursalai and the destruction of the Chera navy
  - The defeat of the Pandya ruler, Amarabhujanga and the establishment of Chola authority in the Pandya country
  - The conquest of Gangavadi, Tadigaipadi and Nolambapadi located in the Mysore region
  - Annexation of northern Sri Lanka. The capital was shifted from Anuradhapura to Polanaruva where a Shiva temple was built
  - Victory over the growing power of the western Chalukyas of Kalyani. Rajaraja I captured Raichur doab, Banavasi and other places. Hence the Chola power extended upto the Tungabhadra river
  - The restoration of the Vengi throne by defeating the Telugu Chodas

- Rajaraja gave his daughter in marriage to Vimaladitya
- Rajaraja's last military achievement- Naval expedition against the Maldives which were conquered
- By these conquests, the extent of the Chola empire increased tremendously far and wide
- Titles assumed by Rajaraja- Mummidi Chola, Jayankonda and Sivapadasekara
- He was a devout follower of Saivism
- He completed the construction of the famous Rajarajeswara temple or Brihadeeswara temple at Tanjore in 1010 CE
- He also helped in the construction of a Buddhist monastery at Nagapattinam

### **Rajendra I (1012-1044 CE)**

- He continued his father's policy of aggressive conquests and expansion
- Important wars:
  - He defeated Mahinda V, the king of Sri Lanka and seized the southern Sri Lanka bringing the whole country under the Chola empire
  - He reasserted the Chola authority over the Chera and the Pandya countries
  - He defeated Jayasimha II, the western Chalukya king and the river Tungabhadra was recognized as the boundary between the Cholas and Chalukyas
  - He defeated a number of rulers on its way of expedition to north India
  - He defeated Mahipala I of Bengal and to commemorate this successful north Indian campaign he founded the city of Gangaikondacholapuram and constructed the famous Rameshwaram temple in that city
  - Naval expedition of Kadaram of Sri Vijaya which was a complete success. He assumed the title Kadaram Kondan
- Titles- most famous ones were Mudikondan, Gangaikondan, Kadaram Kondan and Pandita Cholan. Like his father, he was also a devout Saiva and built a temple for the God at the new capital Gangaikondacholapuram
- He made liberal endowments to this temple and to the Lord Nataraja temple at Chidambaram
- He was also tolerant towards the Vaishnava and Buddhist sects

### **Other rulers:**

- Kulottunga I and Kulottunga III
- Kulottunga I was the grandson of Rajendra I through his daughter Ammangadevi
- During his reign, Sri Lanka became independent
- Kulottunga III- During his reign, the central authority became weak. The rise of the feudatories and the emergence of the Pandya power as a challenge to the Chola supremacy contributed to the ultimate downfall of the Chola empire
- Rajendra III was the last Chola king who was defeated by Jatavarman Sundarapandya II. The Chola country was absorbed into the Pandya empire

### **Chola administration**

### **Central government**

- The emperor or the king was at the top
- The big capital cities like Tanjore and Gangaikondacholapuram, the large royal courts and extensive grants to the temples reveal the authority of the king
- They undertook royal tours to increase the efficiency of the administration
- There was elaborate administrative machinery comprising various officials called perundanam and sirudanam

### **Revenue**

- The land revenue department was called puravubarithinaikkalam
- All lands were carefully surveyed and classified for assessment of revenue
- The residential portion of the village was called ur nattam. These and certain other lands, were exempted from tax
- Kulottunga I became famous by abolishing tolls and earned the title- Sungam Tavirtta Cholan

### **Military administration**

- The Cholas maintained a regular standing army consisting of elephants, cavalry, infantry and navy
- The royal troops were called Kaikkolaperumpadai
- Personal troops, within royal troops, were there, to defend the king and were known as Velaikkaran
- The Cholas paid special attention to their navy and they controlled the Malabar and Coromandel coasts

### **Provincial administration**

- The Chola empire was divided into mandalams and each mandalam into valanadus and nadus
- In each nadu there were a number of autonomous villages
- The royal princes or officers were in charge of mandalams
- The valanadu was under periyannattar and nadu under nattar
- The town was known as nagaram and it was under the administration of a council called nagarattar

### **Village assemblies**

- Comprises of sabhas and their committees
- That village was divided into thirty wards and each was to nominate its members to the village council

- Qualifications to become ward member:
  - Ownership of at least one fourth veli of land
  - Own residence
  - Above thirty years and below seventy years of age
  - Knowledge of vedas
- Norms for disqualification:
  - Those who had been members of the committees for the past three years
  - Those who had failed to submit accounts as committee members
  - Those who had committed sins
  - Those who had stolen properties of others
- Two inscriptions belonging to the period of Parantaka I found at Uthiramerur provide details of the formation and functions of village councils
- The committee members were called variya perumakkal

### **Socio-economic life**

- Caste system was widely prevalent
- Brahmins and Kshatriyas enjoyed special privileges
- The inscriptions of the later period of the Chola rule mention about two major divisions among the castes- Valangai and Idangai castes
- The position of women did not improve
- The practice of Sati was prevalent among the royal families
- The devadasi system of dancing girls attached to temples emerged during this period
- Both Saivism and Vaishnavism continued to flourish during the Chola period
- A number of temples were built and the mathas had great influence during this period
- Both agriculture and industry flourished
- The weaving industry, particularly the silk-weaving at Kanchi flourished
- Commerce and trade were brisk with trunk roads or peruvazhis and merchant guilds
- Gold, silver and copper coins were issued
- Commercial contacts between the Chola empire and China, Sumatra, Java and Arabia were prevalent
- Arabian horses were imported in large numbers to strengthen the cavalry

### **Education and literature**

- Several educational institutions also flourished, an inscription at Ennayiram, Thirumukkudal and Thirubhuvanai provide details of the colleges existed in these places
- Apart from the Vedas and the epics, subjects like mathematics and medicine were taught in these institutions. Endowments of lands were made to run these institutions
- The development of Tamil literature of Tamil literature reached its peak during the Chola period
- Sivakasintamani written by Thiruthakkadevar and Kundalakesi belonged to the 10th century



- Two masterpieces- Ramayana composed by Kamban and the Periyapuram or Thiruthondar Puranam by Sekkilar
- Kalingattupparani- by Jayankondar describes the Kalinga war fought by Kulottunga I
- The Moovarula written by Ottakuthar depicts the life of three Chola kings
- The Nalavenba was written by Pugalandi
- Works on Tamil grammar:
  - Kalladam by Kalladanar
  - Yapperungalam by Amrithasagarar, a Jain
  - Nannul by Pavanandhi
  - Virasoliyam by Buddhaitra

### **Art and architecture**

- The Dravidian style of art and architecture reached its perfection under the Cholas
- The chief feature was its vimana
- The Big Temple at Tanjore was built by Rajaraja I. it consists of the vimana, ardha mandapa, maha mandapa and a large pavilion in the front known as the Nandi Mandapa
- Siva temple at Gangaikonda Cholapuram was built by Rajendra I
- Later Chola temples- The Airavatesvara temple at Darasuram in Tanjore district and the Kampaharesvara temple at Thirubhuvanam

### **Sculptures**

- Found on the walls of the Chola temples such as the ones at Tanjore and Gangaikondacholapuram
- The bronze of this period is world famous
- Masterpiece- the bronze statues of Nataraja or dancing Siva
- The Chola paintings were found on the walls of Narthamalai and Tanjore temples

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## **Influence Of India In Contemporary Asian Countries**

The spread of Indian culture and civilization to other parts of Asia constitutes an important part of the Indian history. It resulted in the spread of Indian languages, culture, religions, art and architecture, philosophy, beliefs, customs and manners. Indian political adventure even established Hindu kingdoms in some parts of SouthEast Asia. However, this did not lead to any kind of colonialism or imperialism. On the other hand, these colonies in the new lands were free from the control of the mother country.

### **Central Asia**

- Central Asia was a great centre of Indian culture in the early centuries of the Christian era
- Important centres of Indian culture:
  - Several monuments have been unearthed in the eastern part of Afghanistan
  - Khotan and Kashkar
  - Several Sanskrit texts and Buddhist monasteries were found in these places
- Indian culture had also spread to Tibet and China through Central Asia

### **India and China**

- Land route- passing through Central Asia
- Sea route- through Burma
- Buddhism reached China in the beginning of the first century CE
- Chinese pilgrims who visited India- Fa Hien and Hiuen Tsang
- Buddhist monks like Gunabhadra, Vajrabhoti, Dharmadeva and Dharmagupta visited China
- Other factors- Indian scholars translated many Sanskrit works at the request of Chinese emperors
- Chinese art had also been influenced by Indian art

### **India and Tibet**

- Tibet was influenced by India since the 7th century CE
- The famous Buddhist king Gampo founded the city of Lhasa and introduced Buddhism
- Role of Indian scholars:
  - Helped in devising the Tibetan alphabet
  - Helped for the establishment of Lamaism in Tibet
- In the 11th century, the Pala dynasty of Bengal had close contacts with Tibet
- When Bengal was attacked by the Muslim rulers, many Buddhist monks sought shelter in Tibet

### **India and Sri Lanka**

- Buddhist missionaries had spread not only the religious faith but also cultural traditions
- The art of stone carving went to Sri Lanka from India
- In the 5th century, Buddha Ghosha visited Sri Lanka and consolidated there the Hinayana Buddhism
- The famous paintings of Sigiriya were modelled on the Ajanta paintings

### **Indian culture in South-East Asia**

- Consisting the regions of the Malay archipelago and Indo-China which are located across the Bay of Bengal

- Being fertile and rich in minerals, these lands attracted the attention of the Indians, generally named Suvarnabhumi (the land of gold)
- Also, the east coast of India is studded with numerous ports
- Indians began to colonize East Asia in the Gupta period. It was further encouraged by the Pallavas and Indian culture dominated this region till the arrival of Islam in the 15th century

### **Cambodia (Kambhoja)**

- Cambodia was colonized by Indians in the 1st century CE. They influenced the native people called the Khemers
- The ruling dynasty was known as the Kambojas and their country was Kamboja or modern Cambodia
- Under the early rulers Saivism and Vaishnavism made steady progress
- Extent of the empire- Laos, Siam, parts of Burma and the Malay peninsula
- A number of Hindu literary works like the Vedas, the Ramayana, the Mahabharata, Panini's grammar, Hindu philosophical treatises were all known to the people of Cambodia
- Like the Pallava kings, they were called Varmans
- Well-known rulers- Yasovarman and Suryavarman II
- Temples were built in the South Indian style
- Most famous temple- The temple (wat) of Vishnu (Angkor Wat temple) built by Suryavarman II in his capital city Angkor
- The temple is constructed on the Dravidian style and the sculptures depict episodes from the Ramayana and the Mahabharata
- The Kamboja kingdom declined only in the 15th century

### **Champa**

- Champa or South Annam is situated to the east of Cambodia
- The first Hindu dynasty was established by Sri Mara in the 2nd century CE
- Twelve Indian dynasties ruled over Champa and by the 13th century, Champa was annexed to Cambodia
- Hindu rulers introduced the Hindu religion and culture, customs and manners and Saivism and Vaishnavism flourished
- Buddhism also existed side by side. Various works on Hindu philosophy, grammar, fine arts and astrology were written

### **Siam or Thailand**

- Thai script was developed with the help of Indian scholars
- On the model of the Dharmashastras, the traditional laws of that country were composed
- The temples at Bangkok contain many sculptures depicting the Ramayana

## Sumatra and Java

- Several Hindu kingdoms existed here between the 5th and 15th centuries
- The most important Hindu kingdom in the big island of Sumatra was Sri Vijaya
- The Sri Vijaya kingdom developed into a powerful maritime and commercial power known as the Sailendra empire extending its sway over the neighboring islands of Java, Bali, Borneo and over Cambodia
- The Sailendra rulers were Mahayana Buddhists and maintained cordial relations with the Indian kingdoms of Palas of Bengal and the Cholas of Tamil Nadu
- Rajaraja Chola allowed the Sailendra king Maravijayottungavarman to build a Buddhist monastery at Nagapattinam
- The Sailendra empire continued intact till the 11th century CE
- A Hindu kingdom was established in Java as early as the 4th century CE
- In Central Java arose the kingdom of Mataram which became a strong centre of Hindu religion and culture. It was conquered by the Sailendras of Sumatra
- After the 9th century, Java gained its independence
- Greatest monument of Indo-Java art- Borobudur, built during the 750-850 CE under the patronage of Sailendras
- Situated on top of a hill, consists of nine successive terraces, crowned by a bell-shaped stupa at the centre of the topmost terrace
- Known as an epic in stone and the most wonderful Buddhist stupa worldwide
- 12th century- eastern Java with Kadiri as its capital developed into a leading Javan kingdom
- 13th and 14th centuries- golden age of Javanese culture. Majapahit became the capital
- Indian art and literature flourished in Java to a great extent
- The Ramayana and Mahabharata were popular and even today furnish the theme for their popular shadow-play

## Bali

- Came under the rule of Hindu dynasties as early as the 6th century
- I-Tsing refers to the prevalence of Buddhism there in the 7th century
- The stone and copper plate inscriptions from that island show that it was colonised directly from India
- Its people continue to be Hindus and even today we find the prevalence of the caste system there

## Myanmar

- The cultural contacts date back to the period of Asoka, who sent his missionaries there to preach Buddhism
- Pali and Sanskrit were the languages of Burma till the 13th century
- Both Hinayana and Mahayana Buddhism were followed by the Burmese

Thus, for nearly 1500 years, Hindu kings were ruling over numerous kingdoms in the Malay archipelago and over the Indo-China peninsula.

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## Early Medieval Indian Period

After the death of Harsha, there was a lack of political unity in north India and the country was split up into a number of States.

The important kingdoms in north India were Kashmir, Gandhara, Sind, Gujarat, Kannauj, Ajmir, Malwa, Bengal and Assam.

### Rajput kingdoms

- The dominance of Rajputs began from the 7th and 8th centuries and lasted till the Muslim conquest in the 12th century
- Theories about the origin of Rajputs- considered as the descendants of the foreign invaders and the Indian Kshatriyas
- Chief occupation- war, trade and agriculture also prospered

The Gurjara- Pratiharas: earliest of the Rajput rulers

- Harishchandra was its first great leader
- Contest of Pratiharas- Palas of Bengal and the Rashtrakutas of the Deccan
- The Chauhans ruled Ajmer  
Vigraharaj was their most important king, who occupied Delhi
- The Paramars- the most important king was Bhoja. His military conquests as well as cultural contributions remain notable in the history of Rajputs

### Arab conquests of Sind (712 CE)

- The religion Islam was born at Mecca in Arabia
- Founder- Prophet Mohammad
- He migrated to Medina in 622 CE, which was the starting point of the Muslim calendar and the Muslim era called Hijra
- After eight years, he returned to Mecca with his followers. He died in 632 CE
- The followers of Muhammad set up an empire called the Caliphate
- The Umayyads and the Abbasids were called the Caliphs

Invasion of Sind:

- Occurred in 712 CE by Muhammad bin Qasim
- He was the commander of the Umayyad kingdom
- Qasim extended the conquest further into Multan

- Qasim organized the administration of Sind. The people of Sind were given the status of zimmi (protected subjects) and Qasim was recalled by the Caliph
- The expansion of Muslims in India was obstructed by powerful Pratihara kingdom in western India

#### Diffusion of Indian culture abroad through the Arabs

- Through many Arab travelers who visited Sind
- Indian medicine and astronomy were carried to far off lands
- The Indian numerals in the Arabic form went to Europe

#### Mahmud of Ghazni and his invasions (997-1030 CE)

- Mahmud is said to have made seventeen raids into India
- North India at the time of his invasion- it was divided into a number of Hindu states
- Campaigns of Ghazni-
  - His initial raids were against Hindu Shahi kingdom which extended from Punjab to Kabul
  - Its king Jayapala was defeated in 1001
  - His successor Anandapala fought against Mahmud but he was also defeated in the Battle of Waihind, the Hindu Shahi capital near Peshawar in 1008
  - Result- Mahmud extended his rule over most of Punjab
  - In 1011, he raided Nagarkot in the Punjab hills and Thaneswar near Delhi
  - In 1018, Mahmud plundered Mathura and also attacked Kannauj
  - His next important and last campaign in India was against Gujarat when he sacked the famous temple of Somnath
  - Mahmud died in 1030 CE
- Results of his invasions:
  - He paved the way for the Turks and Afghans for further conquests
  - He drained the resources of India by his repeated raids and deprived India of her manpower

#### Mahmud's empire

- Punjab in the east to Caspian sea in the west and from Samarkand in the north to Gujarat in the South
- The Ghaznavid empire included Persia, Trans-oxiana, Afghanistan and Punjab
- Poet-laureates in his court:
  - Firdausi was the author of Shah Namah
  - Alberuni wrote the famous Kitab-i-Hind, an account of India

#### Mohammad Ghori

- The Ghoris started as vassals of Ghazni but became independent after the death of Mahmud
- After the decline of the Ghaznavid empire, Muizzuddin Muhammad popularly known as Muhammad Ghori brought Ghazni under their control in this direction
- In 1175, Ghori captured Multan and occupied the whole of Sind. In 1186, he attacked Punjab and annexed his dominion eastward to the Sutlej and led his invasion of the Chauhan kingdom

### **Battle of Tarain (1191-1192)**

- First Battle of Tarain- near Delhi, occurred under the command of Prithviraj Chauhan in which Ghori got defeated (1191)
- Second Battle of Tarain- in 1192, it was a decisive battle and was a major disaster for the Rajputs. Prithviraj was captured and killed
- Result- the first Muslim kingdom was finally established in India at Ajmer and a new era in the history of India began
- Aftermath- Mohammad Ghori returned to Ghazni and left his general Qutbuddin Aibak to make further conquests in India

### **Qutbuddin Aibak**

- Consolidated his position in India by occupying places like Delhi and Meerut
- In 1193, he prepared the ground for another invasion by Mohammad Ghori
- This invasion was directed against the Gahadavala ruler Jayachandra. Muhammad routed Jayachandra's forces
- Kannauj was occupied by the Muslims after the Battle of Chandawar
- The battles of Tarain and Chandawar contributed to the establishment of the Turkish rule in India

### **Causes for the failure of Hindu kingdoms**

- Lack of unity
- Many Hindu states were declining in power
- Outdated military methods
- Indians continued to rely on elephants while the Muslims possessed quick-moving cavalry
- The Muslim soldiers had better organization and able leaders
- Among the Hindus, the duty of fighting was confined to a particular class, the Kshatriyas

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## **Delhi Sultanate**

The Muslim invasions into India had ultimately resulted in the establishment of Delhi Sultanate which existed from A.D. 1206 to 1526. **Five different dynasties – the Slave, Khalji, Tughlaq, Sayyids and Lodhis – ruled under the Delhi Sultanate.**

## SLAVE DYNASTY

- The Slave dynasty was also called Mamluk (Slave) dynasty. The Slave dynasty ruled Delhi from A.D. 1206 to 1290.
- In fact, three dynasties were established during this period. They were

Qutbi dynasty (1206-1211) founded by Qutbuddin Aibak.

First Ilbari dynasty (1211- 1266) founded by Iltutmish.

Second Ilbari dynasty (1266-1290) founded by Balban.

## QUTBUDDIN AIBAK (1206-1210)

- Qutbuddin Aibak was a slave of Muhammad Ghori, who made him the Governor of his Indian possessions.
- He assumed the title Sultan and made Lahore his capital after the death of Ghori.
- Muslim writers call **Aibak Lakh Baksh or giver of lakhs** because he gave liberal donations to them.
- **Aibak patronized the great scholar Hasan Nizami.**

## ILTUTMISH (1211-1236)

- Iltutmish belonged to the **Ilbari tribe** and hence his dynasty was named as Ilbari dynasty.
- The Mongol policy of Iltutmish saved India from the wrath of Chengiz Khan.
- Mongol Policy:- Temujin popularly known as Chengiz Khan, the leader of the Mongols, started invading Central Asia. He defeated Jalaluddin Mangabarni, the ruler of Khwarizmi. Mangabarni crossed the river Indus and sought asylum from Iltutmish. Iltutmish refused to give him shelter in order to save his empire from the onslaught of the Mongols.
- **Minhaj-us-Siraj, Taj-ud-din., Nizam-ul-mulk, Muhammad Janaidi, Malik Qutb-ud-din Hasan and Fakhru-Mulk Isami** were his contemporary scholars who added grandeur to his court.
- Apart from completing the **construction of Qutub Minar at Delhi** (started by Qutbuddin Aibak), **the tallest stone tower in India (238 ft.)**, he built a magnificent mosque at Ajmer.
- Iltutmish introduced the Arabic coinage into India and the silver tanka weighing 175 grams became a standard coin in medieval India.
- Iltutmish had also created a new class of the ruling elite of forty powerful military leaders, the Forty.



### **RAZIYA (1236-1240)**

Itutmish nominated his daughter Raziya as his successor. ( First female ruler of India )

### **ERA OF BALBAN (1246-1287)**

- Ghiyasuddin Balban, who was also known as Ulugh Khan, served as Naib or regent to Sultan Nasiruddin Mahmud (Younger son of Itutmish).
- Balban introduced rigorous court discipline and new customs such as prostration and kissing the Sultan's feet to prove his superiority over the nobles.
- He also introduced the Persian festival of Nauroz to impress the nobles and people with his wealth and power.
- He established a separate military department - diwan-i-arz – and reorganized the army.

### **THE KHALJI DYNASTY (1290-1320)**

- The advent of the Khalji dynasty marked the zenith of Muslim imperialism in India. The founder of the Khalji dynasty was Jalaluddin Khalji.
- Alauddin Khalji treacherously murdered his father-in-law Jalaluddin Khalji and usurped the throne of Delhi.

### **ALAUDDIN KHALJI (1296-1316)**

- He was convinced that the general prosperity of the nobles, intermarriages between noble families, inefficient spy-system and drinking liquor were the basic reasons for the rebellions.
- He confiscated the properties of the nobles. The intelligence system was reorganized and all the secret activities of the nobles were immediately reported to the Sultan.
- The public sale of liquor and drugs was totally stopped. Social gatherings and festivities without the permission of the Sultan were forbidden. By such harsh measures his reign was free from rebellions.

### **REFORMS OF ALAUDDIN KHALJI**

- He recruited 4,75,000 cavalrymen. He introduced the system of dagh (branding of horses) and prepared huliya (descriptive list of soldiers).
- The introduction of paying salaries in cash to the soldiers led to price regulations popularly called as Market Reforms.
- Alauddin Khalji established four separate markets in Delhi, one for grain; another for cloth, sugar, dried fruits, butter and oil; a third for horses, slaves and cattle; and a fourth for miscellaneous commodities.
- Each market was under the control of a high officer called Shahna-i-Mandi.
- A separate department called Diwan I Riyasat was created under an officer called Naib-i-Riyasat.

- There were secret agents called munhiyans who sent reports to the Sultan regarding the functioning of these markets.
- He was the first Sultan of Delhi who ordered for the measurement of land. Even the big landlords could not escape from paying land tax. Land revenue was collected in cash in order to enable the Sultan to pay the soldiers in cash.

## **MILITARY CAMPAIGNS**

- The northwestern frontier was fortified and Ghazi Malik was appointed as the Warden of Marches to protect the frontier.
- In 1301, Alauddin marched against Ranthampur and after a three month's siege it fell. The Rajput women committed jauhar or self-immolation.
- Alauddin next turned against Chittor. In 1303 Alauddin stormed the Chittor fort. Raja Ratan Singh and his soldiers fought valiantly but submitted. The Rajput women including Rani Padmini performed jauhar. This Padmini episode was graphically mentioned in the book Padmavat written by Jayasi.
- Alauddin Khalji's greatest achievement was the conquest of Deccan and the far south. This region was ruled by four important dynasties – Yadavas of Devagiri, Kakatiyas of Warangal, Hoysalas of Dwarasamudra and the Pandyas of Madurai.
- Alauddin Khalji died in 1316. Although the Sultan was illiterate, he patronized poets like Amir Khusrau and Amir Hasan. He also built a famous gateway known as Alai Darwaza and constructed a new capital at Siri.
- Ghazi Malik, the governor of Dipalpur, killed the Sultan Khusru Shah and ascended the throne of Delhi under the title of Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq in 1320.

## **THE TUGHLAQ DYNASTY (1320-1414)**

- The founder of the Tughlaq dynasty was Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq. Ghiyasuddin laid the foundation for Tughlaqabad near Delhi.
- Ulugh Khan was said to have treacherously killed his father and ascended the throne with the title Muhammad bin Tughlaq in 1325.

## **MUHAMMAD BIN TUGHLAQ (1325-1351)**

- Muhammad bin Tughlaq was the only Delhi Sultan who had received a comprehensive literary, religious and philosophical education.

## **TRANSFER OF CAPITAL**

- Muhammad bin Tughlaq wanted to make Devagiri his second capital so that he might be able to control South India better.
- In 1327 he made extensive preparations for the transfer of the royal household and the ulemas and Sufis from Delhi to Devagiri, which was renamed as Daulatabad.

## **TOKEN CURRENCY**

- Muhammad bin Tughlaq issued copper coins at par with the value of the silver tanka coins.

## **TAXATION IN DOAB**

- In order to overcome financial difficulties, Muhammad bin Tughlaq increased the land revenue on the farmers of Doab (land between Ganges and Yamuna rivers).
- A severe famine was also ravaging that region at that time. It had resulted in a serious peasant revolt.

## **AGRICULTURAL REFORMS**

- He launched a scheme by which taccavi loans (loans for cultivation) were given to the farmers to buy seed and to extend cultivation.
- A separate department for agriculture, Diwan-i-Kohi was established. Model farm under the state was created in an area of 64 square miles for which the government spent seventy lakh tankas. This experiment was further continued by Firoz Tughlaq.

## **REBELLIONS**

- The rebellion of Hasan Shah resulted in the establishment of the Madurai Sultanate. In 1336 the Vijayanagar kingdom was founded. In 1347 Bahmani kingdom was established.
- In Gujarat Taghi rose in revolt against the Sultan who spent nearly three years chasing him. Muhammad bin Tughlaq's health became worse and he died in 1351.

## **FIROZ TUGHLAQ (1351-1388)**

- He appointed Khan-i-Jahan Maqbal, a Telugu Brahmin convert as wazir (prime minister).

## **ADMINISTRATIVE REFORMS**

- He strictly followed the advice of the ulemas in running the administration. He pleased the nobles and assured hereditary succession to their properties (iqta system).
- As per the Islamic law he levied the taxes. Jiziya was strictly imposed on non-Muslims.
- He was the first Sultan to impose irrigation tax. But at the same time he dug irrigation canals and wells. The longest canal was about 200 kilometres from Sutlej to Hansi.
- The special tax on 28 items was abolished by him since they were against the Islamic law.
- He also developed royal factories called karkhanas in which thousands of slaves were employed.
- About 300 new towns were built during his reign. The famous among them was Firozabad near Red Fort in Delhi, now called Firoz Shah Kotla.

- A new department called Diwan-i-Khairat was created to take care of orphans and widows.
- Firoz patronized scholars like Barani and Afif.

### **SAYYIDS (1414-1451)**

- Before his departure from India in 1399, Timur appointed Khizr Khan as governor of Multan. He captured Delhi and founded the Sayyid dynasty in 1414.
- Muhammad Shah died in 1445 and was succeeded by his son Alam Shah (1445-1451) the weakest of the Sayyid princes.

### **LODIS (1451-1526)**

- The Lodis, who succeeded Sayyids, were Afghans. Bahlul Lodi was the first Afghan ruler while his predecessors were all Turks. He died in 1489 and was succeeded by his son, Sikandar Lodi.
- Sikandar Lodi (1489-1517) was the greatest of the three Lodi sovereigns.
- He was a good administrator. Roads were laid and many irrigational facilities were provided for the benefit of the peasantry.
- Despite certain laudable qualities, he was a bigot. He destroyed many Hindu temples and imposed many restrictions on the Hindus.
- Sikandar Lodi was succeeded by his eldest son Ibrahim Lodi who was arrogant. Greatly displeased by the arrogance of Ibrahim, Daulat Khan Lodi invited Babur to invade India.
- Babur marched against Delhi and defeated and killed Ibrahim Lodi in the first battle of Panipat (1526). The Afghan kingdom lasted for only seventy-five years.

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## **India Under The Delhi Sultanate**

### **ADMINISTRATION**

- They included the name of the Caliph in the khutba or prayer and inscribed it on their coins.
- There was no clear law of succession during this period. All the sons had equal claim to the throne. The military superiority remained the main factor in matters of succession.

### **CENTRAL GOVERNMENT**

- The office of the Sultan was the most important in the administrative system. He was the ultimate authority for the military, legal and political activities.
- The post of Naib was the most powerful one. The Naib practically enjoyed all the powers of the Sultan and exercised general control over all the departments.

- Next to him was the Wazir who was heading the **finance department called Diwani Wizarat.**
- **The military department was called Diwani Ariz.** It was headed by **Ariz-i-mumalik.** He was responsible for recruiting the soldiers and administering the military department. He was not the commander-in-chief of the army. **The Sultan was the commander-in-chief of the army.**
- The military department was first set up by Balban and it was further improved by Alauddin Khalji
- **Diwan I Risalat was the department of religious affairs.** It was headed by chief Sadr. Grants were made by this department for the construction and maintenance of mosques, tombs and madrasas.
- The head of the **judicial department was the chief Qazi.** Muslim personal law or sharia was followed in civil matters. The Hindus were governed by their own personal law and their cases were dispensed by the village panchayats
- The **department of correspondence was called Diwani Insha.**

## LOCAL ADMINISTRATION

- The provinces under the **Delhi Sultanate were called iqtas.** They were initially under the control of the nobles. But the **governors of the provinces were called the muqtis or walis.** They were to maintain law and order and collect the land revenue.
- The **provinces were divided into shiqs and the next division was pargana.** The shiq was under the control of shiqdar.
- The pargana comprising a number of villages was headed by amil. The village remained the basic unit of the administration.
- The village headman was known as muqaddam or chaudhri. The village accountant was called patwari.

## DIVISION OF PROVINCE:-

**IQTAS - (Controlled by Muqtis or walis )**

**SHIQS - (Controlled by Shiqdar )**

**PARGANA - (Controlled by Amil )**

**VILLAGE - (Controlled by Muqaddam)**

## ECONOMY

- The lands were classified into three categories: iqta land – lands assigned to officials as iqtas instead of payment for their services. khalisa land – land under the direct control of the Sultan and the revenues collected were spent for the maintenance of royal court and

royal household. inam land – land assigned or granted to religious leaders or religious institutions.

- The peasantry paid one third of their produce as land revenue, and sometimes even one half of the produce.
- **Firoz encouraged the growth of horticulture. Muhammad bin Tughlaq created a separate agricultural department, Diwani Kohi.**
- Overseas trade was under the control of Multanis and Afghan Muslims. Inland trade was dominated by the Gujarat Marwari merchants and Muslim Bohra merchants.
- Sarais or rest houses on the highways were maintained for the convenience of the travelers.
- **Gold coins or dinars became popular during the reign of Alauddin Khalji after his South Indian conquests**

## SOCIAL LIFE

- Traditional caste system with the Brahmins on the upper strata of the society was prevalent. The subservient position of women also continued and the practice of sati was widely prevalent.
- The seclusion of women and the wearing of purdah became common among the upper class women. **The Arabs and Turks brought the purdah system into India.**
- The Hindus were considered zimmi or protected people for which they were forced to pay a tax called jizya.
- In the beginning jizya was collected as part of land tax. **Firoz Tughlaq separated it from the land revenue and collected jizya as a separate tax.**

## ART AND ARCHITECTURE

- **The Turks introduced arches, domes, lofty towers or minarets and decorations using the Arabic script.**
- **The Quwwat-ul-Islam mosque near Qutub Minar in Delhi was built by using the materials obtained from destroying many Hindu and Jain temples.**
- The most magnificent building of the 13th century was the Qutub Minar which was founded by Aibek and completed by Iltutmish. This seventy one metre tower was dedicated to the Sufi saint Qutbuddin Bakhtiyar Kaki.
- The palace complex called Tughlaqabad with its beautiful lake was built during the period of Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq. **Muhammad bin Tughlaq built the tomb of Ghiyasuddin on a high platform.**
- **The Kotla fort at Delhi was the creation of Firoz Tughlaq.** The Lodi garden in Delhi was the example for the architecture of the Lodis.

## MUSIC

- New musical instruments such as sarangi and rabab were introduced during this period. **Amir Khusrau introduced many new ragas such as ghora and sanam.** He evolved a

new style of light music known as **qawwalis by blending the Hindu and Iranian systems.**

- The invention of **sitar was also attributed to him.** The Indian classical work Raag Darpan was translated into Persian during the reign of Firoz Tughlaq. Pir Bhodan, a Sufi saint was one of the great musicians of this period.
- Raja Man Singh of Gwalior encouraged the composition of a great musical work called **Man Kautuhal.**

## LITERATURE

- The most famous historians of this period were Hasan Nizami, Minhaj-us-Siraj, Ziauddin Barani, and Shams-Siraj Afif. Barani's Tarikhi-Firoz Shahi contains the history of the Tughlaq dynasty.
- **Minhaj-us-Siraj wrote Tabaqat-i-Nasari,** a general history of Muslim dynasties up to 1260.
- Amir Khusrau (1252-1325) was the famous Persian writer of this period. He created a new style of **Persian poetry called Sabaqi-Hind or the Indian style.** Amir Khusrau's Khazain-ul-Futuh speaks about Alauddin's conquests. His famous work Tughlaq Nama deals with the rise of Ghiasuddin Tughlaq.
- Sanskrit and Persian functioned as link languages in the Delhi Sultanate. Zia Nakshabi was the first to translate Sanskrit stories into Persian. The book Tutu Nama or Book of the Parrot became popular and translated into Turkish and later into many European languages.
- The famous Rajatarangini written by Kalhana belonged to the period of Zain-ul-Abidin, the ruler of Kashmir.
- **In Arabic, Alberuni's Kitab-ul-Hind is the most famous work.**
- Chand Baradi was the famous Hindi poet of this period.

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## Bhakti Movement

### SUFISM

- It had its origin in Persia and spread into India in the eleventh century.

#### Some Sufi Saints:-

1. Shaikh Ismail of Lahore (First Sufi Saint)
  2. Khwaja Muinuddin Chishti (Ajmer)
- **The first Sufi saint Shaikh Ismail** of Lahore started preaching his ideas.

- The most famous of the Sufi saints of India was **Khwaja Muinuddin Chishti**, who settled in Ajmer which became the centre of his activities. He had a number of disciples who are **called Sufis of the Chishti order**
- Bahauddin Zakariya came under the influence of another famous mystic, **Shihabuddin Suhrawardi**. His branch of Sufi saints was known as the Sufis of the **Suhrawardi Order**.

#### CHARACTERISTIC FEATURES OF SUFISM :-

- Love of God meant love of humanity and so the Sufis believed service to humanity was tantamount to service to God.
- The Sufis lay stress on inner purity.
- The Sufis consider love and devotion as the only means of attaining salvation.

#### BHAKTI MOVEMENT

##### SANKARA

- In the ninth century Sankara gave a new orientation to Hinduism.
- Born in Kaladi in Kerala.
- His doctrine of **Advaita or Monism** was too abstract to appeal to the common man.
- There was a reaction against the Advaita concept of **Nirgunabrahman (God without attributes)** with the emergence of the **idea of Sagunabrahman (God with attributes)**.

##### RAMANUJA

- In the twelfth century, Ramanuja, who was born at Sriperumbudur near modern Chennai, preached **Visishtadvaita**.
- According to him God is **Saguna Brahman**. The creative process and all the objects in creation are **real but not illusory as was held by Sankaracharya**.
- Therefore, God, soul, matter are real. But God is the inner substance and the rest are his attributes.
- He also advocated prabattimarga or path of self-surrender to God.
- He invited the downtrodden to Vaishnavism

##### MADHAVA

- In the thirteenth century, Madhava from Kannada region propagated **Dvaita or dualism** of Jivatma and Paramatma.
- According to his philosophy, **the world is not an illusion but a reality**.

##### NIMBARKA and VALLABHACHARYA

- Preachers of Vaishnavite Bhakti in the Telangana region.

##### SURDAS



- Disciple of Vallabhacharya and he popularized the Krishna cult in north India.

### MIRABAI

- Great devotee of Krishna, she became popular in Rajasthan for her bhajans.

### TULSIDAS

- Worshipper of Rama and composed the famous **Ramcharitmanas, the Hindi version of Ramayana.**
- In the fourteenth and fifteenth centuries, **Ramananda, Kabir and Nanak** remained great apostles of the Bhakti cult. They drew inspiration from old masters but showed a new path.
- They helped the common people to shed age-old superstitions and attain salvation through Bhakti or pure devotion.
- Unlike the early reformers, they were not linked with any particular religious creed and did not believe in rituals and ceremonies.
- **They condemned polytheism and believed in one god.** They also denounced all forms of idolatry.
- They strongly believed in **Bhakti as the only means of salvation.** They also emphasised the fundamental unity of all religions.

### RAMANANDA

- Born at Allahabad.
- Originally a **follower of Ramanuja**, later founded his own sect and preached his principles in Hindi at Banaras and Agra.
- He was a worshipper of Rama. He was the first to employ the vernacular medium to propagate his ideas.
- Simplification of worship and emancipation of people from the traditional caste rules were his two important contributions to the Bhakti movement.
- **He opposed the caste system** and chose his disciples from all sections of society disregarding caste.

### KABIR

- Among the disciples of Ramananda the most famous was Kabir. He was born near Banaras.
- Kabir's object was **to reconcile Hindus and Muslims** and establish harmony between the two sects.
- He **denounced idolatry and rituals** and **laid great emphasis on the equality of man before God.**

- He emphasized the essential **oneness of all religions** by describing **Hindus and Muslims 'as pots of the same clay'**.
- He regarded devotion to God as an effective means of salvation and urged that to achieve this one must have a pure heart, free from cruelty, dishonesty, hypocrisy and insincerity.
- **His followers are called Kabirpanthis.**

## GURU NANAK

- **Founder of the Sikh religion** and a disciple of Kabir. He was born in Talwandi near Lahore.
- He denounced caste distinctions and rituals like bathing in holy rivers.
- He exhorted people to give up selfishness, falsehood and hypocrisy and to lead a life of truth, honesty and kindness. 'Abide pure amidst the impurities of the world' was one of his famous sayings.

## CHAITANYA

- Well-known saint and reformer of Bengal who popularised the Krishna cult. He proclaimed the universal brotherhood of man and condemned all distinctions based on religion and caste.
- He emphasized love and peace and showed great sympathy to the sufferings of other people, especially that of the poor and the weak.

**GNANADEVA** was the founder of the **Bhakti Movement in Maharashtra** in the thirteenth century. He **wrote a commentary on Bhagavad Gita called Gnaneswari.**

## NAMADEVA

- preached the gospel of love. He opposed idol worship and priestly domination. He also opposed the caste system.

**EKANATHA** opposed caste distinctions and sympathetic towards the lower castes

**TUKARAM, a contemporary of King Shivaji.** He was responsible for creating a background for Maratha nationalism. He opposed all social distinctions.

## IMPORTANCE OF THE BHAKTI MOVEMENT

- It provided an impetus for the development of regional languages such as Hindi, Marathi, Bengali, Kannada, etc. Through these languages they made direct appeal to the masses.
- As the caste system was condemned by the Bhakti saints, the lower classes were raised to a position of great importance.

- The importance of women in society was also increased because the Bhakti movement gave equal importance to them.
  - The Bhakti movement gave to the people a simple religion, without complicated rituals. They were required to show sincere devotion to God.
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## Vijayanagar And Bahamani Kingdoms

### VIJAYANAGAR EMPIRE

- Four dynasties – Sangama, Saluva, Tuluva and Aravidu – ruled Vijayanagar from A.D. 1336 to 1672.
- **Krishnadevaraya's Amuktamalyada, Gangadevi's Madhuravijayam and Allasani Peddanna's Manucharitam** are some of the indigenous literature of this period.

### POLITICAL HISTORY

- Vijayanagar was founded in 1336 by **Harihara and Bukka of the Sangama dynasty** on the south bank of the **Tungabhadra river**.
- The struggle between Vijayanagar and the Sultanate of Madurai lasted for about four decades. Kumarakampana's expedition to Madurai was described in the Madhuravijayam.
- He destroyed the Madurai Sultans and as a result, **the Vijayanagar Empire comprised the whole of South India up to Rameswaram**.
- **The greatest ruler of the Sangama dynasty was Deva Raya II**. After his death, the Sangama dynasty became weak. The next dynasty, Saluva dynasty founded by Saluva Narasimha reigned only for a brief period (1486-1509).

### KRISHNA DEVA RAYA (1509 – 1530)

- **The Tuluva dynasty was founded by Vira Narasimha**. The greatest of the Vijayanagar rulers, **Krishna Deva Raya belonged to the Tuluva dynasty**.
- He possessed great military ability. His imposing personality was accompanied by high intellectual quality.
- The Muslim armies were decisively defeated in the battle of Diwani by Krishna Deva Raya. Then he invaded Raichur Doab which had resulted in the confrontation with the Sultan of Bijapur, Ismail Adil Shah. But, Krishna Deva Raya defeated him and captured the city of Raichur in 1520.
- He defeated the Gajapathi ruler Prataparudra and conquered the whole of Telangana. He maintained **friendly relations with the Portuguese**. Albuquerque sent his ambassadors to Krishna Deva Raya.
- **Though a Vaishnavite, he respected all religions**. He was a great patron of literature and art and **he was known as Andhra Bhoja**.

- Eight eminent scholars known as **Ashtadiggajas** were at his royal court. **Allasani Peddanna was the greatest and he was called Andhrakavita Pitamaga**. His important works include **Manucharitam and Harikathasaram**.
- **Pingali Suranna and Tenali Ramakrishna** were other important scholars.
- Krishna Deva Raya authored a **Telugu work, Amuktamalyada** and **Sanskrit works, Jambavati Kalyanam and Ushaparinayam**.
- He also built the famous **Vittalaswami and Hazara Ramaswamy temples at Vijayanagar**.
- He also built a new city **Nagalapuram** in memory of his **queen Nagaladevi**. Besides, he built a large number of Rajagopuram.
- After his death, Achyuta Deva and Venkata succeeded to the throne. During the reign of Rama Raya, the combined forces of Bijapur, Ahmadnagar, Golkonda and Bidar defeated him at the Battle of Talikota in 1565. This battle is also known as Raksasa Tangadi. This battle was generally considered to mark the end of the Vijayanagar Empire.
- However, the Vijayanagar kingdom existed under the Aravidu dynasty for about another century. Thirumala, Sri Ranga and Venkata II were the important rulers of this dynasty. The last ruler of Vijayanagar kingdom was Sri Ranga III.

## ADMINISTRATION

- The administration was well organized.
- The king enjoyed absolute authority in executive, judicial and legislative matters. He was the highest court of appeal.
- The succession to the throne was on the **principle of hereditary status**. The king was assisted by a council of ministers in his day to day administration.
- The Empire was divided into different administrative units called **Mandals, Nadus, sthalas and gramas**. The governor of Mandalam was called **Mandaleswara or Nayak**.
- Vijayanagar rulers gave **full powers to the local authorities** in the administration.
- Besides land revenue, tributes and gifts from vassals and feudal chiefs, customs collected at the ports, taxes on various professions were other sources of income to the government. Land revenue was fixed generally one sixth of the produce.
- The expenditure of the government includes personal expenses of the king and the charities given by him and military expenditure.
- In the matter of justice, harsh punishments such as mutilation and throwing to elephants were followed.
- The Vijayanagar army was well-organized and efficient. It consisted of the cavalry, infantry, artillery and elephants. High-breed horses were procured from foreign traders.
- The top-grade officers of the army were known as Nayaks or Poligars. They were granted land in lieu of their services. These lands were called amaram. Soldiers were usually paid in cash.

## SOCIAL LIFE

- Allasani Peddanna in his Manucharitra refers to the existence of four castes – Brahmins, Kshatriyas, Vaisyas and Sudras - in the Vijayanagar society.
- Paes mentions the beautiful houses of the rich and the large number of their household servants. **Nicolo Conti refers to the prevalence of slavery.**
- Dancing, music, wrestling, gambling and cock-fighting were some of the amusements.
- The Sangama rulers were chiefly **Saivaites and Virupaksha** was their family deity. But other dynasties were Vaishnavites.
- **Borbosa** referred to the religious freedom enjoyed by everyone. Muslims were employed in the administration and they were freely allowed to build mosques and worship.
- **The position of women had not improved.** Gangadevi, wife of Kumara Kampana authored the famous work Madura Vijayam. Hannamma and Thirumalamma were famous poets of this period.
- The attachment of dancing girls to temples was in practice. Paes refers to the flourishing **devadasi system**. **Polygamy was prevalent** among the royal families. **Sati was honoured.**

## ECONOMIC CONDITION

- The Vijayanagar Empire was one of the wealthiest parts of the world at that time. **Agriculture** continued to be the **chief occupation of the people**. Irrigation facilities were present.
- **Metal workers and other craftsmen flourished during this period. Diamond mines were located in Kurnool and Anantapur district.**
- **The chief goldcoin was the varaha but weights and measures varied from place to place.**
- There were a number of seaports on the Malabar coast, the chief being Cannanore.
- The chief items of exports were cotton and silk clothes, spices, rice, iron, saltpeter and sugar. The imports consisted of horses, pearls, copper, coral, mercury, China silk and velvet clothes. The art of shipbuilding had developed.

## CULTURAL CONTRIBUTIONS

- The chief characteristics of the Vijayanagara architecture were the construction of tall **Raya Gopurams or gateways and the Kalyanamandapam** with carved pillars in the temple premises.
- The **horse was the most common animal** found in these pillars. Large mandapams contain one hundred pillars as well as one thousand pillars in some big temples.
- The most important temples of the Vijayanagar style were found in the **Hampi ruins**. **Vittalaswamy and Hazara Ramaswamy temples were the best examples of this style.**
- The **Varadharaja and Ekambaranatha temples** at Kanchipuram stand as examples for the magnificence of the Vijayanagara style of temple architecture.

- The **Raya Gopurams at Tiruvannamalai and Chidambaram** speak of the glorious epoch of Vijayanagar.
- The metal images of Krishna Deva Raya and his queens at Tirupati are examples for casting of metal images.
- Different languages such as Sanskrit, Telugu, Kannada and Tamil flourished in the regions. The peak of literary achievement was reached during the reign of Krishna Deva Raya. He was a scholar in Sanskrit and Telugu. His famous court poet Allasani Peddanna was distinguished in Telugu literature.

## BAHMANI KINGDOM

- The founder of the Bahmani kingdom was **Alauddin Bahman Shah** also known as Hasan Gangu in 1347. Its capital was Gulbarga.
- Ahmad Wali Shah shifted the capital from Gulbarga to Bidar. The power of the Bahmani kingdom reached its peak under the rule of Muhammad Shah III.
- The success of Muhammad Shah was due to the advice and services of his minister Mahmud Gawan.

## MAHMUD GAWAN

- The Bahmani kingdom reached its peak under the guidance of Mahmud Gawan. He was a Persian merchant. He possessed a great **knowledge of mathematics**.
- He made endowments to build a college at Bidar which was built in the Persian style of architecture. He was also a military genius.
- His conquests include **Konkan, Goa and Krishna-Godavari delta**.
- His administrative reforms were aimed to increase the control of the Sultan over the nobles and provinces. Royal officers were appointed in each province for this purpose. Most of the forts were under the control of these officers.
- Allowances were reduced to the nobles who shirked their responsibility. This was disliked by the nobles. So, the Deccani nobles organised a plot against Gawan. They induced the Sultan to punish him with a death sentence.
- By the year 1526, the Bahmani kingdom had disintegrated into five independent sultanates. **They were Ahmednagar, Bijapur, Berar, Golkonda and Bidar and known as Deccan Sultanates.**

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# The Mughal Empire

## BABUR (1526-1530)

- Babur was the **founder of the Mughal Empire in India**. Babur succeeded his father Umar Shaikh Mirza as the ruler of Farghana.
- Babur took interest in conquering India and launched four expeditions between 1519 and 1523.

### MILITARY CONQUESTS

- On the eve of Babur's invasion of India, there were five prominent Muslim rulers – the Sultans of Delhi, Gujarat, Malwa, Bengal and the Deccan – and two prominent Hindu rulers – Rana Sangha of Mewar and the Vijayanagar Empire.
- On 21st April 1526 the **first Battle of Panipat** took place between **Babur and Ibrahim Lodi, who was killed in the battle**.
- Babur's success was due to his cavalry and artillery. Babur proclaimed himself as **"Emperor of Hindustan"**.
- Rana Sanga of Mewar marched against Babur and in the Battle of Khanwa (near Agra) held in 1527 Babur won a decisive victory over him. Babur assumed the title Ghazi.
- In 1528, Babur captured Chanderi from another Rajput ruler Medini Rai. In the next year, Babur defeated the Afghans in the Battle of Gogra in Bihar.

### ESTIMATE OF BABUR

- He was also a great **scholar in Arabic and Persian languages**. Turki was his mother tongue. He wrote his memoirs, Tuzuk-i-Baburi in the Turki language.

### HUMAYUN (1530-1540)

- Humayun was the eldest son of Babur. Humayun means "fortune" but he remained the most unfortunate ruler of the Mughal Empire.
- Humayun marched against Sher Khan and in the Battle of Chausa, held in 1539, Sher Khan destroyed the Mughal army and Humayun escaped from there.
- Humayun reached Agra to negotiate with his brothers. But as they were not cooperative, Humayun was forced to fight with Sher Khan alone in the Battle of Bilgram in 1540. This battle was also known as the Battle of Kanauj. Humayun was thoroughly defeated by Sher Khan.

### SUR INTERREGNUM (1540-1555)

- The founder of the **Sur dynasty was Sher Shah**.

### SHER SHAH SUR (1540-1545)

- His empire consisted of the whole of North India except Assam, Nepal, Kashmir and Gujarat

## SHER SHAH'S ADMINISTRATION

- The king was assisted by four important ministers.
  1. **Diwan –i- Wizarat** – also called as Wazir - in charge of Revenue and Finance.
  2. **Diwan-i-Ariz** – in charge of the Army.
  3. **Diwan-i-Risalat**- Foreign Minister.
  4. **Diwan-i-Insha**- Minister for Communications
- Sher Shah's empire was divided into forty seven sarkars. **Chief Shiqdar (law and order)** and **Chief Munsif (judge)** were the two officers in charge of the administration in each sarkar. Each sarkar was divided into several parganas.
- **Shiqdar (military officer)**, **Amin (land revenue)**, **Fotedar (treasurer)** **Karkuns (accountants)** were in charge of the administration of each pargana. There were also many administrative units called iqtas.
- All cultivable lands were classified into three classes – good, middle and bad. The state's share was one third of the average produce and it was paid in cash or crop.
- Sher Shah introduced new silver coins called "Dam" and they were in circulation till 1835.
- Sher Shah had also improved communications by laying four important highways. They were: 1. Sonargaon to Sind 2. Agra to Burhanpur 3. Jodhpur to Chittor and 4. Lahore to Multan.
- Police were efficiently reorganized and crime was less during his regime.

## ESTIMATE OF SHER SHAH

- Sher Shah remained a pious Muslim and generally **tolerant towards other religions**.
- He built a new city on the banks of the river Yamuna near Delhi. He also built a Mausoleum at Sasaram, which is considered as one of the masterpieces of Indian architecture.
- **Malik Muhammad Jayasi wrote the famous Hindi work Padmavat during his reign.**

## HUMAYUN (1555-1556)

- When Humayun left India in 1540, he married Hamida Banu Begum on his way to Sind. When they stayed in Amarkot, a Hindu kingdom ruled by Rana Prasad, Akbar was born in 1542.
- In 1555, Humayun defeated the Afghans and recovered the Mughal throne.
- He was a student of mathematics, astronomy and astrology. He also loved painting and wrote poetry in Persian language.

## AKBAR (1556-1605)

- Akbar was one of the greatest monarchs of India.
- In the second Battle of Panipat in 1556, Hemu(Commander-in-chief of Afghanistan) was almost on the point of victory. But an arrow pierced his eye and he became unconscious. His army fled and the fortune favoured Akbar. The Mughal victory was decisive.



- He conquered northern India from Agra to Gujarat and then from Agra to Bengal. He strengthened the northwest frontier.

### RELATIONS WITH RAJPUTS

- He married the Rajput princess, the daughter of Raja Bharamal. It was a turning point in the history of Mughals. Raja Bhagawan Das and Raja Man Singh were given senior positions in the administration by Akbar.
- But the Ranas of Mewar continued to defy despite several defeats. In the Battle of Haldighati, Rana Pratap Singh was severely defeated by the Mughal army led by Man Singh in 1576.
- **He abolished the pilgrim tax and later the jizya.**
- The Rajput policy of Akbar proved to be beneficial to the Mughal state as well as to the Rajputs.

### RELIGIOUS POLICY

- In the beginning of his life, Akbar was a pious Muslim. Soon after marrying Jodh Bai of Amber, he abolished the pilgrim tax and in 1562, **he abolished jizya**. He allowed his Hindu wives to worship their own gods.
- In 1575, he ordered for the **construction of Ibadat Khana (House of worship)** at his new capital Fatepur Sikri.
- He **disliked the interference of the Muslim Ulemas in political matters**. In 1579, he issued the "Infallibility Decree" by which he asserted his religious powers.
- In 1582, he promulgated a **new religion called Din Ilahi or Divine Faith**. It believes in **one God**. It contained the good points of all religions. Its basis was rational. However, his new faith proved to be a failure.

### LAND REVENUE ADMINISTRATION

- Akbar made some experiments in the land revenue administration with the help of Raja Todar Mal. The land revenue system of Akbar was called **Zabti or Bandobast system**. It was known as the Dahsala **System** which was completed in 1580.
- By this system, Todar Mal introduced a uniform system of land measurement. The revenue was fixed on the average yield of land assessed on the basis of the past ten years.
- The land was also divided into four categories – Polaj (cultivated every year), Parauti (once in two years), Chachar (once in three or four years) and Banjar (once in five or more years). Payment of revenue was made generally in cash.

### MANSABDARI SYSTEM

- **Akbar introduced the Mansabdari system in his administration**. Under this system every officer was assigned a rank (mansab).

- The lowest rank was 10 and the highest was 5000 for the nobles. The ranks were divided into two – zat and sawar. Zat means personal and it fixed the personal status of a person. Sawar rank indicated the number of cavalymen of a person who was required to maintain.
- Every sawar had to maintain at least two horses. The mansab rank was not hereditary. All appointments and promotions as well as dismissals were directly made by the emperor.

### **JAHANGIR (1605-1627)**

- When Akbar died, Prince Salim succeeded with the title Jahangir (Conqueror of World) in **1605**. His son Khusrau revolted but was defeated and imprisoned. **One of his supporters, Guru Arjun, the fifth Sikh Guru, was beheaded.**

### **NUR JAHAN**

- In 1611, Jahangir married Mehrunnisa who was known as Nur Jahan (Light of World).
- In 1612, Asaf Khan's daughter, Arjumand Banu Begum (later known as Mumtaz), married Jahangir's third son, prince Khurram (later Shah Jahan).
- It was believed by some historians that Nur Jahan formed a group of "junta" and this led to two factions in the Mughal court. She encouraged Persian art and culture in the court.

### **SHAH JAHAN (1627-1658)**

- Shah Jahan carved four Mughal provinces in the Deccan – Khandesh, Berar, Telungana and Daulatabad. They were put under the control of his son Aurangzeb.

### **WAR OF SUCCESSION**

- The last years of Shah Jahan's reign were clouded by a bitter war of succession among his four sons – Dara Shikoh (crown prince), Shuja (governor of Bengal), Aurangzeb (governor of Deccan) and Murad Baksh (governor of Malwa and Gujarat).
- Shah Jahan lived for eight long years lovingly nursed by his daughter Jahanara. He died in 1666 and was buried beside his wife's grave in the Taj Mahal.

### **AURANGAZEB (1658-1707)**

- Aurangzeb was one of the ablest of the Mughal kings. He assumed the title Alamgir, World Conqueror.

### **DECCAN POLICY**

- The Deccan policy of the Mughals started from the reign of Akbar, who conquered Khandesh and Berar. Jahangir fought against Malik Amber of Ahmednagar. During the

Shah Jahan's reign, Aurangzeb, as governor of Deccan, followed an aggressive Deccan policy.

- To contain the spread of the Marathas, Aurangzeb decided to invade Bijapur and Golconda. He defeated Sikandar Shah of Bijapur and annexed his kingdom. Then, he proceeded against Golkonda and eliminated the **Qutb Shahi dynasty**.
- His Deccan campaigns exhausted the Mughal treasury.

## RELIGIOUS POLICY

- Aurangzeb was a staunch and orthodox Muslim in his personal life. His ideal was to transform India into an Islamic state. He created a separate department to enforce moral codes under a high-powered officer called Muhtasib. Drinking was prohibited.
- Cultivation and use of bhang and other drugs were banned.
- **Aurangzeb forbade music in the Mughal court.** He discontinued the practice of Jharokha Darshan. He also discontinued the celebration of Dasara and royal astronomers and astrologers were also dismissed from service.
- Initially Aurangzeb banned the construction of new Hindu temples and repair of old temples. Then he began a policy of destroying Hindu temples. The celebrated temples at Mathura and Benares were reduced to ruins. In 1679, **he reimposed jizya and pilgrim tax.**
- The celebration of Muharram was stopped. His invasions against the Deccan sultanates were partly due to his hatred of the Shia faith.
- **He was also against the Sikhs and he executed the ninth Sikh Guru Tej Bahadur.**
- **His religious policy was responsible for turning the Rajputs, the Marathas and Sikhs into the enemies of Mughal empire.** It had also resulted in the rebellions of the Jats of Mathura and the Satnamis of Mewar. Therefore, Aurangzeb was held responsible for the decline of the Mughal empire.

## PERSONALITY AND CHARACTER OF AURANGAZEB

- Aurangzeb was industrious and disciplined.
- He was very simple in food and dress. **He earned money for his personal expenses by copying the Quran and selling those copies.**
- He was learned and proficient in Arabic and Persian languages. He was a lover of books. He was devoted to his religion and conducted prayers five times a day. He strictly observed the Ramzan fasting.
- **Aurangzeb was an orthodox Sunni Muslim.** But his move to apply his religious thought rigidly in a non-Muslim society was a failure. His antagonistic policies towards non-Muslims did not help him to rally the Muslims to his side.

## CAUSES FOR THE DOWNFALL OF THE MUGHALS

- The weakness of the empire was exposed when Nadir Shah imprisoned the Mughal Emperor and looted Delhi in 1739.

- The religious and Deccan policies of Aurangzeb contributed to its decline.
  - The weak successors and demoralization of the Mughal army also paved the way for it.
  - The financial difficulties due to continuous wars led to the decline. The neglect of the sea power by the Mughals was felt when the Europeans began to settle in India.
  - Thus the decline and downfall of the Mughal Empire was due to the combination of political, social and economic factors.
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## **India under the Mughals**

### **Economic and social life**

- The Mughal period saw important social and economic development
- Accounts given by European travelers and traders-
  - About the socio-economic conditions of India
  - Wealth and prosperity of India
  - Luxurious life of the aristocratic classes
  - Mentioned the poverty and sufferings of the ordinary people such as peasants and artisans

### **Mughal nobility**

- The nobles of the Mughal period were mainly foreigners such as Turks and Afghans
- From the time of Akbar, the Hindus, particularly the Rajputs were included in the nobility (eg- Raja Man Singh, Raja Birbal and Raja Todar Mal)
- Marathas also joined the Mughal service later on
- The Mughal nobles were paid high salaries and lived a luxurious lifestyle
- They also made costly presents to the emperors

### **Rural masses**

- Poor people suffered from insufficient clothing even during the winter
- Nikitin observed that the people of Deccan were barefooted
- Staple food of the common people- rice, millet and pulses and the fish was popular in the coastal region
- As plenty of cattle were kept by the rural people, milk and milk products were available in plenty

### **Agriculture**

- A large variety of crops such as wheat, rice, gram, barley, pulses were cultivated
- Commercial crops such as cotton, indigo, sugarcane and oilseeds were also cultivated
- During the 17th century, two new crops namely- tobacco and maize were added

- Potato and red chillies came later in the 18th century
- No new agricultural technique during this period but India was able to export food items like rice and sugar to the neighboring countries

### **Growth of trade**

- The Indian trading classes were well organized and highly professional
- Seth, bohra traders were specialized in long distance trade
- Local traders were called banik
- Banjaras- They were specialized in carrying bulk goods and used to move to long distances with their goods on oxen backs
- Bulk goods were also taken through rivers on boats. The trading community did not belong to one caste or religion
- Multanis, Khattris and Afghans conducted trade with Central asia
- In south India, the Chettis on the Coromandel coast and the Muslim merchants of Malabar were the most important trading communities
- Bengal exported sugar, rice as well as delicate muslin and silk
- The Coromandel coast became a centre of textile production
- Gujarat was an entry point of foreign goods. From there, fine textiles and silk were taken to north India
- Indigo and food grains were exported from north India through Gujarat
- The major imports into India were certain metals such as tin and copper, war horses and luxury items such as ivory
- The balance of trade was maintained by the import of gold and silver
- The growth of foreign trade had resulted in the increased import of gold and silver in the 17th century
- The Dutch and English traders who came to Gujarat during the 17th century, found that Indian traders were alert and brisk

### **Cultural development under the Mughals**

Indian traditions were blended with Turko-Iranian culture which was brought into India by the Mughals.

### **Art and Architecture**

- Types of architecture- magnificent forts, palaces, public buildings, mosques and mausoleums
- The Mughals were fond of laying gardens with running water. Ex- Nishat bagh in Kashmir, the Shalimar Bagh at Lahore and the Pinjore garden in Punjab
- During the reign of Sher Shah, the Mausoleum at Sasaram in Bihar and the Purana Qila near Delhi were built. These two monuments are considered as the architectural marvels of medieval India

- Shah Jahan- The climax of fort-building reached its climax during his reign. His creations are- the famous Red Fort at Delhi with its Rang Mahal, Diwan-i-Am and Diwan-i-Khas

### **Akbar**

- Agra Fort- built in red sandstone
- Akbar also built a palacecum-fort complex at Fatehpur Sikri (City of Victory).
- The most magnificent building in it-
  - Jama Masjid
  - Gateway to it is called Buland Darwaza or the Lofty Gate. Built to commemorate Akbar's victory over Gujarat
  - Jodh Bai's palace and Panch Mahal with five storeys
- During Akbar's reign, the Humayun's tomb was built in Delhi and it has a massive dome of marble
- It may be considered as the precursor of Taj Mahal
- Akbar's tomb at Sikandara near Agra was completed by Jahangir
- Nur Jahan built the tomb of Itimaddaulah at Agra. It was constructed wholly out of white marble with floral designs made of semi-precious stones on the walls. This type of decoration was called pietra dura
- This method became more popular during the reign of Shah Jahan
- Taj Mahal is considered a jewel of the builder's art
- Mosque building had reached its peak during Shah Jahan's reign
- The Moti Masjid at Agra was built entirely in white marble
- The Jama Masjid at Delhi, was built in red sandstone

### **Paintings and music**

- The foundation for the Mughal painting was laid by Humayun
- He brought with him two painters- Mir Sayyid Ali and Abdal Samad to India. These two painters became famous during Akbar's reign
- Akbar invited a large number of painters from different parts of the country to his court. Both Hindus and Muslims joined
- Akbar's court artists- Baswan, Miskina and Daswant
- Illustrations of Persian versions of Mahabharata and Ramayana were produced in miniature form
- Akbar Nama also remained the main theme of Mughal paintings. The most important work is Hamzanama, which consisted 1200 paintings
- Colors used- peacock blue, Indian red
- Mughal paintings reached its climax during the reign of Jahangir. He employed a number of painters like Abul Hasan, Bishan Das, Madhu, Anant, Manohar, Govardhan and Ustad Mansur
- Apart from paintings, the scenes of hunting, battles and royal courts, progress was made in portrait paintings and paintings of animals

### **Music developed under the Mughals**

- Akbar patronized Tansen of Gwalior
- Tansen composed many ragas
- Jahangir and Shah Jahan were also fond of music

### **Language and literature**

- Persian language became widespread in the Mughal empire by the time of Akbar's reign
  - Abul Fazl was a great scholar and historian who set a style of prose writing
  - He wrote Ain-i-Akbari and Akbarnama
  - Abul Faizi- the leading poet of that period who was his brother. The translation of Mahabharata into the Persian language was done under his supervision
  - Utbi and Naziri were two other leading Persian poets
  - Jahangir's autobiography was- Tuzuk-i-Jahangiri
  - Shah Jahan also patronized many writers and historians like
    - Abdul Hamid Lahori, author of Padshahnama
    - Inayat Khan, author of Shah Jahan Nama
  - His son Dara Shikoh translated the Bhagavad Gita and Upanishads into Persian language
  - Regional languages such as Bengali, Odia, Rajasthani and Gujarati had also developed during this period
  - Many devotional works including the Ramayana and Mahabharata were translated into regional languages
  - From the time of Akbar, Hindi poets were attached to the Mughal court
  - The most influential Hindi poet was Tulsidas, who wrote the Hindi version of the Ramayana, the Ramacharitamanas
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## **The Marathas**

### **The Rise of the Marathas**

Various factors contributed to the rise of the Marathas in the 16th and 17th centuries.

- Physical environment- mountains regions and dense forests made them brave soldiers and adopt guerilla tactics
- They built a number of forts on the mountains
- The spread of the Bhakti movement in Maharashtra
- The spiritual leaders like Tukaram, Ramdas, Vaman Pandit and Eknath fostered social unity
- Political unity was conferred by Sivaji

- The Marathas held important positions in the administrative and military systems of Deccan Sultanates of Bijapur and Ahmednagar

### **Shivaji (1627-1680)**

- Shivaji was born at Shivner in 1627
- His father was Shahji Bhonsle and mother Jija Bai
- After the death of his guardian, Dadaji Kondadev in 1647, Shivaji assumed full charge of his jagir

### **Conquest**

- He captured Javli from a Maratha chief, Chanda Rao More. This made him the master of the Mavala region
- In 1657, he attacked the Bijapur kingdom and captured a number of hill forts in the Konkan region
- The Sultan of Bijapur sent Afzal Khan against Shivaji. But he was murdered in 1659

### **Shivaji and Aurangzeb**

- Shivaji lost Poona by Mughal forces when Aurangzeb sent the Mughal governor of the Deccan, Shaista Khan against him.. But Shivaji once again made a bold attack on Shaista Khan's military camp at Poona in 1663, killed his son and wounded Khan
- In 1664, Shivaji attacked Surat, the chief port of the Mughals and plundered it
- Aurangzeb sent Raja Jai Singh of Amber to fight against Shivaji. Shivaji opened negotiations with Jai Singh and the Treaty of Purandar was signed in 1665
- Shivaji visited Agra in 1666, but he was imprisoned there. However, he managed to escape from prison
- He plundered Surat for the second time in 1670
- He also captured all of his lost territories by his conquests
- In 1674, Shivaji crowned himself at Rajgarh and assumed the title Chhatrapati
- Expedition into the Carnatic region- captured Ginjee and Vellore
- After his return from the expedition, Shivaji died in 1680

### **Shivaji's administration**

The king was the pivot of the government. Ashtapradhan- a council of ministers to assist the King and each one was responsible directly to Shivaji

- Peshwa- finance and general administration. Later, he became prime minister
- Sar-i-Naubat or Senapati- military commander, an honorary post
- Amatya- accountant general
- Waqenavis- intelligence, posts and household affairs
- Sachiv- correspondence



- Sumanta- master of ceremonies
- Nyayadhish- justice
- Panditrao- charities and religious administration

Most of the administrative reforms were based on the practices of the Deccan Sultanates.

- Peshwa was the Persian title
- The revenue system was based on that of Malik Amber of Ahmednagar
- Lands were measured by using a measuring rod called kathi
- Lands were also classified into three categories- paddy fields, hilly tracts and garden lands
- He appointed his own revenue officials called karkuns
- Chauth and sardeshmukhi- were the taxes collected in the neighboring territories of Mughal empire of Deccan sultanates (not in the Maratha kingdom)
- Chauth was one fourth of the land revenue paid to the Marathas
- Sardeshmukhi was an additional levy of ten percent on those lands on which the Marathas claimed hereditary rights
- The regular army consisted of 30000 to 40000 cavalry supervised by havildars
- They were given fixed salaries
- There were two divisions in the Maratha cavalry-
  - Bargirs- equipped and paid by the state
  - Silahdars- maintained by the nobles
- In the infantry, the Mavli foot soldiers played an important role
- Shivaji also maintained a navy
- Forts played an important role in the military operations. By the end of his reign, Shivaji had over 240 forts
- He was a daring soldier and a brilliant administrator

### **Successors of Shivaji**

- There ensued a war of succession between his sons, Sambhaji and Rajaram
- Shambaji emerged victorious but later he was captured and executed by the Mughals
- Rajaram succeeded to the throne but the Mughals made him flee to Gingee Fort. He died at Satara
- He was succeeded by his minor son Shivaji II with his mother Tara Bai as regent
- The next ruler was Shahu in whose reign the Peshwas rose to power

### **The Peshwas (1713-1818)**

#### **Balaji Vishwanath (1713-1720)**

He began his career as a small revenue official and became Peshwa in 1713. As Peshwa, he made his position the most important and powerful, as well as hereditary.

Balaji Vishwanath got certain rights from the then Mughal emperor, Farukh Siyar

- The Mughal emperor recognized Shahu as the Maratha king
- He allowed Shahu to collect Chauth and Sardeshmukhi from the six Mughal provinces of the Deccan including the Carnatic and Mysore

### **Baji Rao I (1720-1740)**

- Eldest son of Balaji Vishwanath, who succeeded his father as Peshwa and that was when their power was at its zenith
- He initiated the system of confederacy among the Maratha chiefs. Under this system, each Maratha chief was given a territory which could be administered autonomously
- Result- many Maratha families became prominent and established their authority in different parts of India
  - Gaekwad- Baroda
  - Bhonsle- Nagpur
  - Holkar- Indore
  - Scindia- Gwalior
  - Peshwa- Poona

### **Balaji Baji Rao (1740-1761)**

He succeeded his father as Peshwa at the young age of nineteen.

Agreement with the Mughal emperor- in 1752

- According to it, the Peshwa gave assurance to the Mughal emperor that he would protect the Mughal empire from internal and external enemies for which the chauth of the northwest provinces and the total revenue of the Agra and Ajmer provinces would be collected by the Marathas
- Thus, when Ahmad Shah Abdali invaded India, it became the responsibility of the Marathas to protect India
- They fought bravely in the Third Battle of Panipat in 1761. But got defeated
- This battle gave a death blow to the Maratha power
- Thereafter, the Maratha confederacy weakened due to internal conflicts among the Maratha chiefs

After the decline of the Mughal empire, the Marathas emerged a great power in India but they could not succeed in preventing the establishment of British power.

Important causes for downfall:

- lack of unity among the Maratha chiefs
- superiority of the British army and their fighting methods

### Chronologically Listed Foreign Travellers To India

|                      |                                                                                     |
|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Megasthenes          | Ambassador of Selucus Nikator to the court of Chandragupta Maurya, Wrote ' Indica ' |
| Fa Hien              | Visited during reign of Chandragupta II ( Vikramaditya )                            |
| Hiuen Tsang          | Visited during reign of Harshavardhana                                              |
| I Tsing              | Major work : Biographies of Eminent Monks                                           |
| Al Msaudi            | His work Muruj-al-Zahab                                                             |
| Al Beruni            | Came along with Mahmud Ghazni, Work : Tahqiq -i-Hind                                |
| Marco Polo           | Venetian, Visited South India during reign of Pandayan ruler Madverman Kulshekhara  |
| Ibn Batuta           | Moroccan, Visited during reign of Muhammad-bin-tughlaq, Work : Rehla                |
| Shihabuddin al-Umari | Damascus                                                                            |
| Nicolo Conti         | Venetian, Gave detailed account of Vijayanagar Empire                               |
| Abdur Razaq          | Persian, Gave vivid account of Vijayanagar Empire                                   |
| Athanasius Nikitin   | Russian, Described Bahamani Kingdom                                                 |
| Duarte Barbosa       | Portuguese, Vijayanagar Empire                                                      |
| Dominigo Paes        | Portuguese, Visited court of Krishnadeva Raya                                       |
| Fernao Nuniz         | Portuguese, Vijayanagar Empire                                                      |
| William Hawkins      | Ambassador of British King James I To Jahangir                                      |
| Sir Thomas Roe       |                                                                                     |
| Peter Mundy          | Italian, Shah Jahan                                                                 |

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|-------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| Jean Baptiste Tavernier | French, Covered Shah Jahan, Aurangzeb |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------------|